Tideline *Journal*

Every day leaves a mark.

USER GUIDE

A private, encrypted journal for Windows. This guide covers every part of the program.

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How to read this guide

Names of buttons and menu items are shown in **this style**, keys look like Ctrl + N, and a path such as **Settings → Your data** means "open Settings, then go to the Your data section".

> TIP
>
> You can reopen this guide at any time from **Settings → Help → User guide**.

> ABOUT THE PICTURES
>
> The screenshots in this guide use made-up example entries, not anyone's real journal.

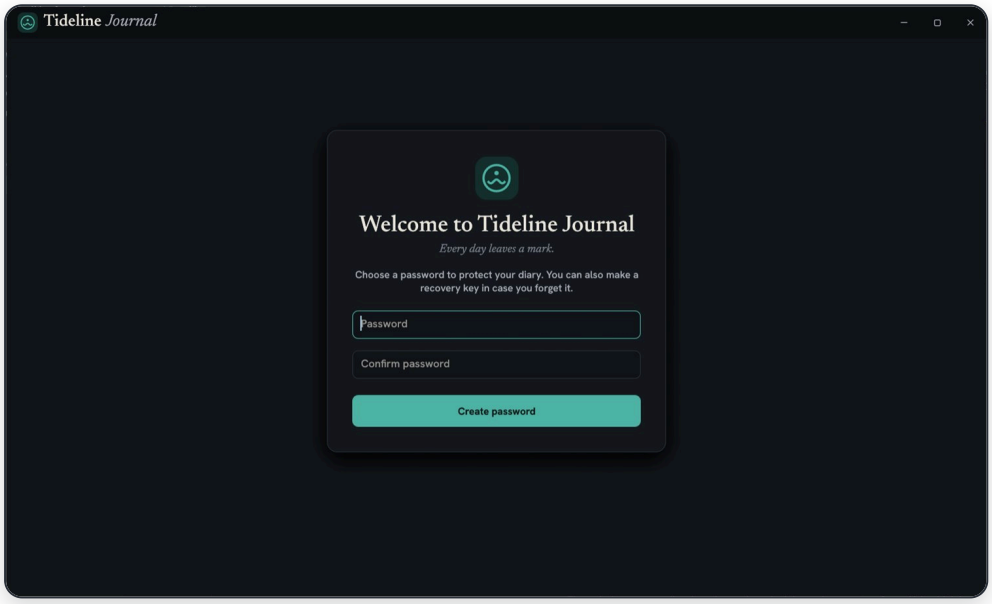
CHAPTER 1

Getting started

Tideline Journal is a private place to write each day. Everything you write is encrypted with your password, and nothing leaves your computer.

Creating your journal

The first time you start the program it asks you to choose a password. Type it twice and press **Create password**.



The first-run screen: choose a password.

- A password must be at least **8 characters**. A short sentence you will remember makes a good password.
- Straight after creating a journal you are offered a **recovery key**. Make one (see chapter 12): it is the only way back in if you ever forget the password.

> **IMPORTANT**
>
> Your journal is encrypted for real. If you forget the password and have no recovery key, **nobody can open it, including the people who made this program**. Make a recovery key and keep it somewhere safe.

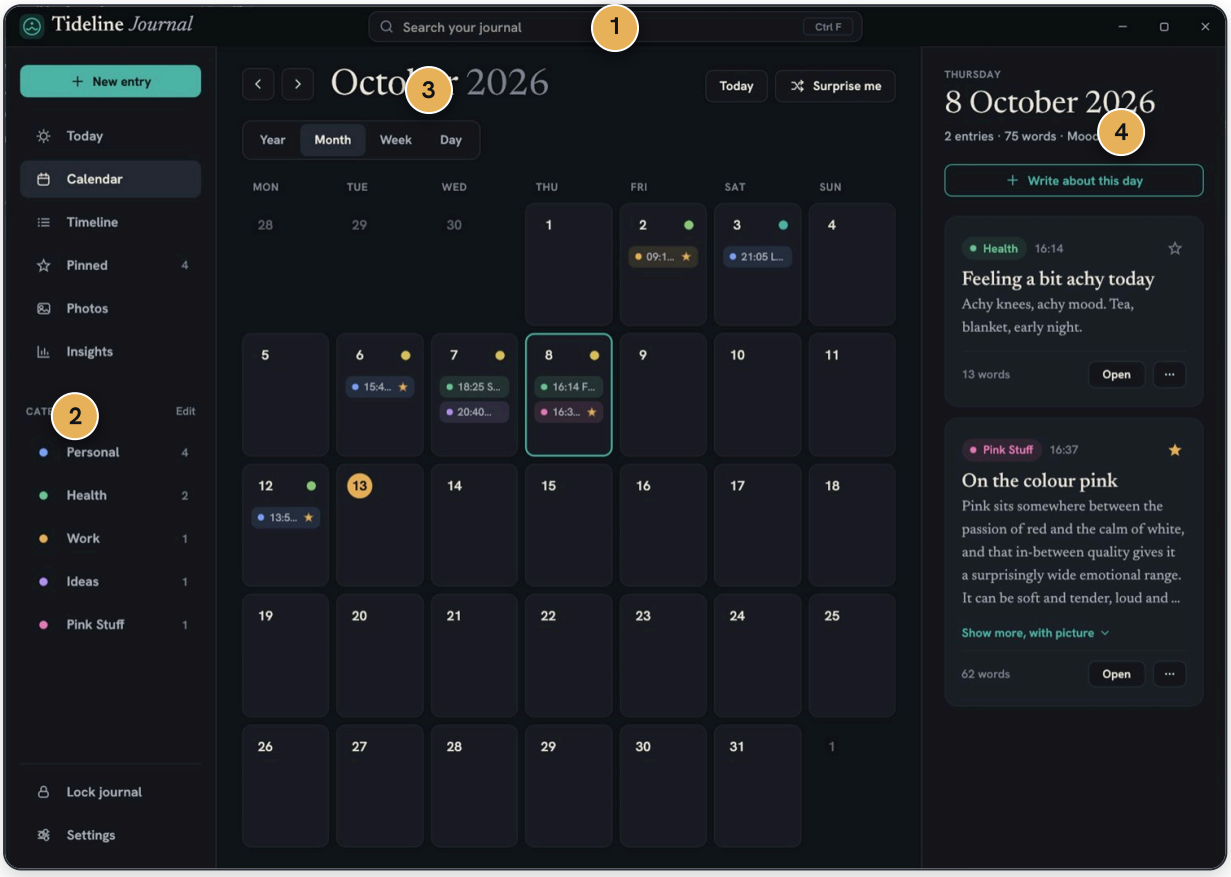
Unlocking and locking

Each time the program starts it shows an unlock screen. Type your password and press Enter. Below the password box are two links: **Forgot your password?** (use a recovery key) and **Open a different diary…** (use a journal stored in another folder, such as a backup).

To lock the journal at any time, press Ctrl + L or choose **Lock journal** at the bottom of the side menu. Locking forgets the decrypted text. If you were in the middle of writing an entry, it is kept in memory and is still there after you unlock.

The journal also locks by itself after a period without activity, and hides itself while the window is in the background (see chapter 12).

Your window at a glance



The main window, with the four areas numbered.

1. **Title bar.** The search box (Ctrl + F) is in the middle and the window buttons are on the right. Drag the bar to move the window; double-click it to maximise or restore.
2. **Side menu.** **New entry**, places to go (Today, Calendar, Timeline, Pinned, Photos, Insights), your categories with a count of entries, then **Lock journal** and **Settings**.
3. **The calendar.** Arrows, the month title, **Today** and **Surprise me**, and the Year / Month / Week / Day switch.
4. **The day panel.** A summary of the day you have selected, with its entries as cards.

> **TIP**
>
> You can make everything bigger or smaller with Ctrl + + and Ctrl + − (and Ctrl + 0 to reset). F11 switches full screen on and off.

CHAPTER 2

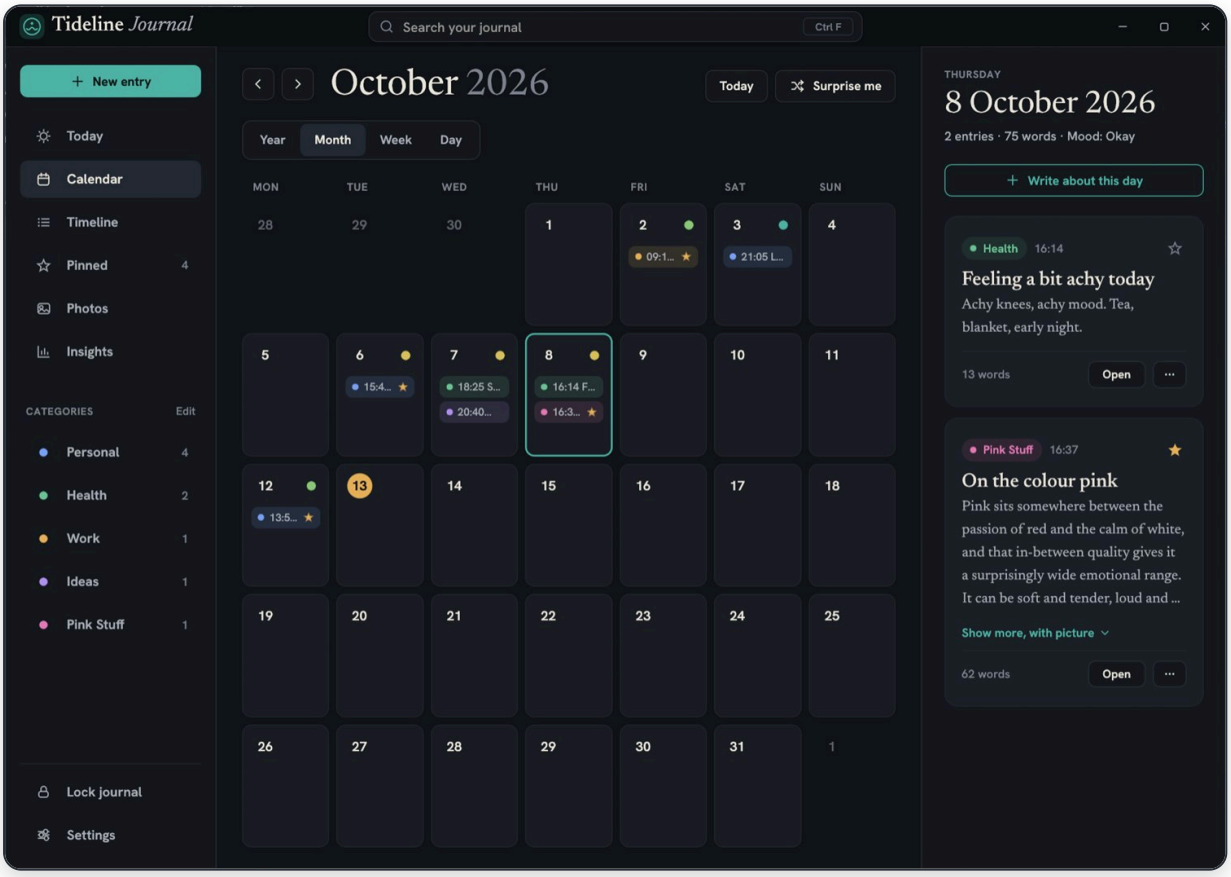
The calendar

The calendar shows what you have written and when. Click any day to select it and see its entries on the right.

Month view

This is the view you start in. Each day is a tile:

- The **date number** is at the top left. **Today** sits in an amber circle, and the **selected day** has a teal outline. Days belonging to the previous or next month are dimmed.
- A small **coloured dot** at the top right shows the day's average mood, from red (Awful) through amber to teal (Great).
- Each entry appears as a **chip**: a dot in its category colour, the time and the title. A star on a chip means it is pinned. If a day has more entries than fit, the tile says "+2 more": click the day to see them all on the right.



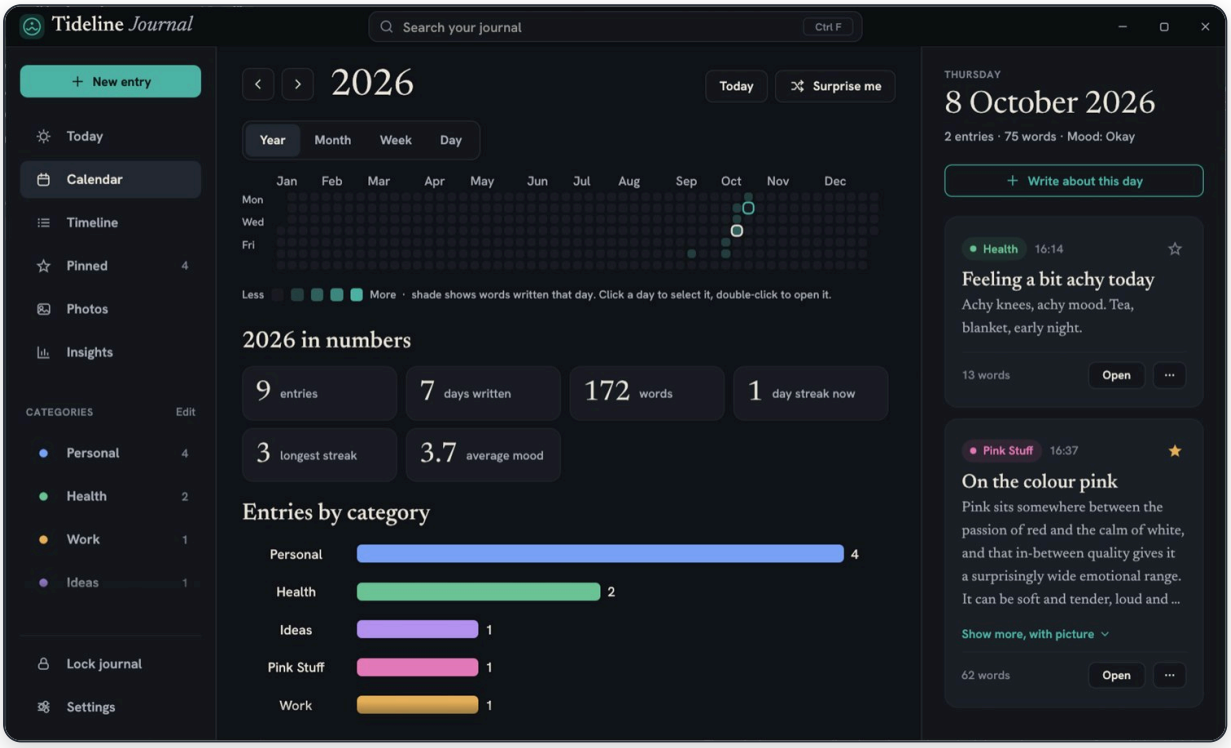
Month view. Today is circled in amber; the 8th is selected.

Year, Week and Day views

Use the switch under the month title (or `Ctrl` + `1` to `Ctrl` + `4`).

Year

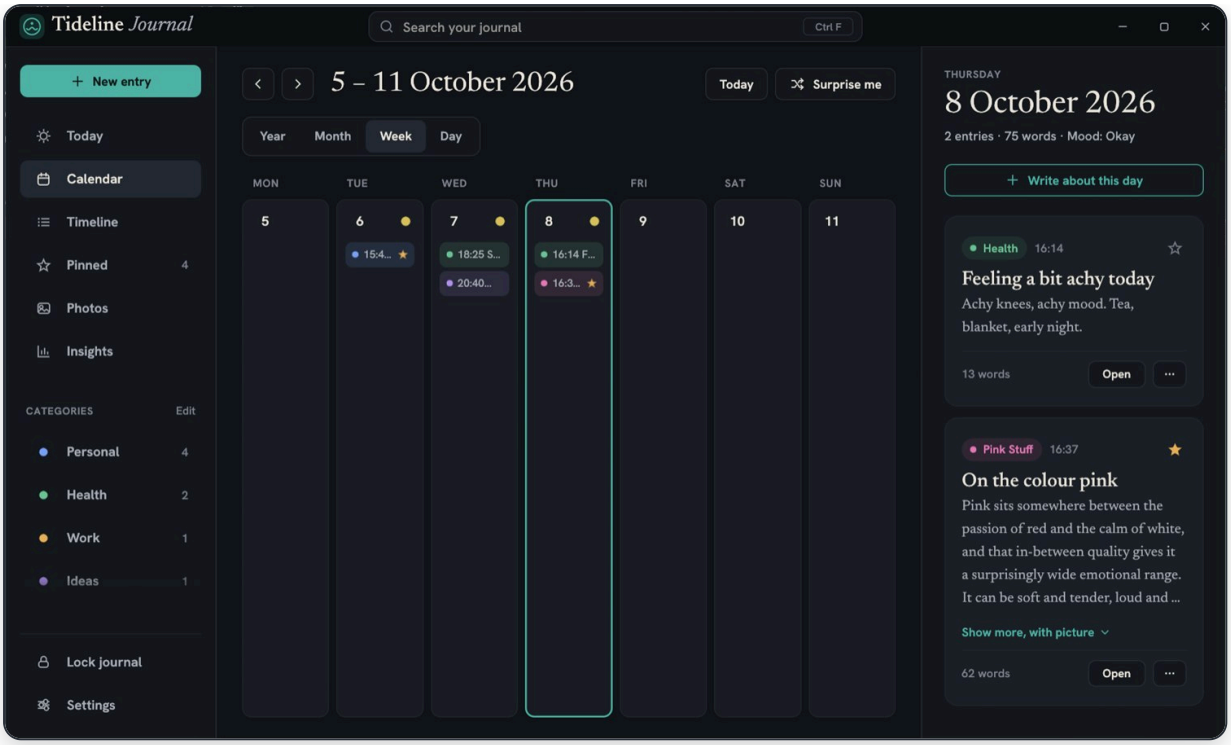
A heat-map with one small square per day: the more you wrote, the brighter the square. Hover for the date and word count, click to select a day, double-click to open it in Day view. Underneath are your totals for the year (entries, days written, words, current and longest writing streak, average mood), entries per category and a chart of your mood through the year.



Year view: the heat-map and your year in numbers.

Week

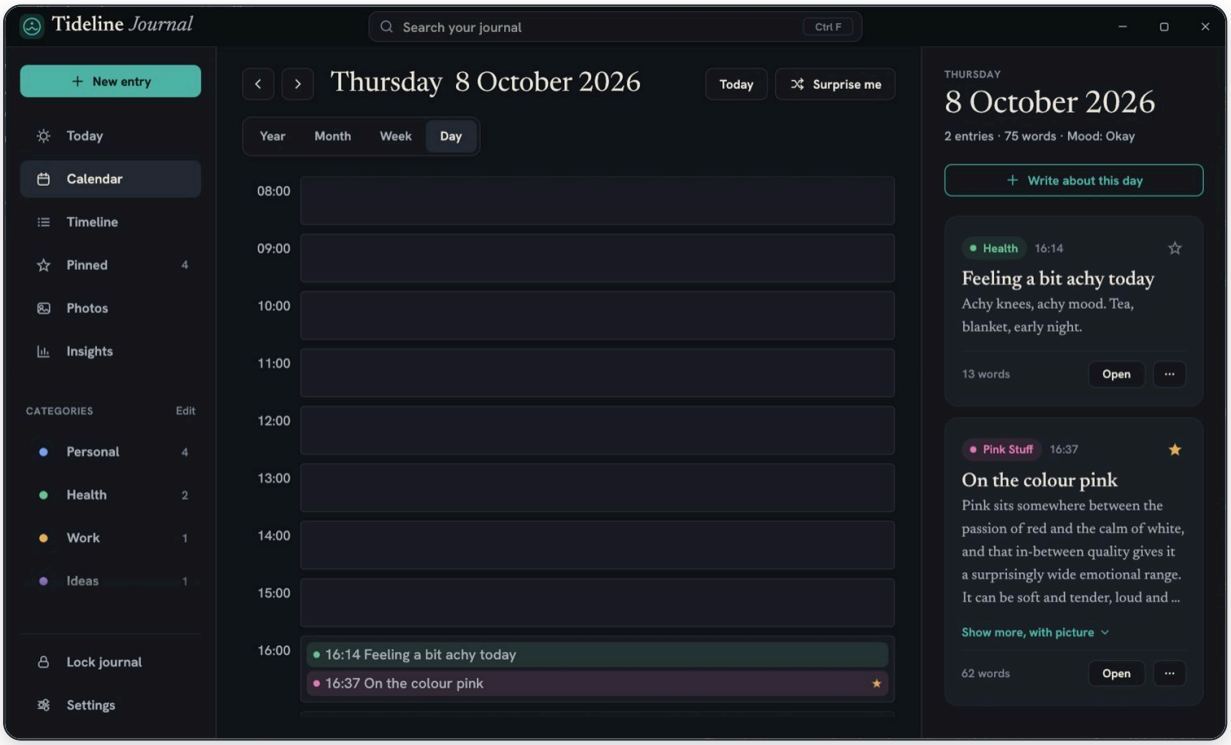
Seven tall columns, one per day, with more room for each entry's chip.



Week view.

Day

The selected day hour by hour. Entries sit in the hour they were written.



Day view: a timeline from the morning onwards.

Moving around

TO DO THIS	DO THIS
Step back or forward	The ‹ and › buttons, or the ← and → keys. In Month view this moves a month; in Week, a week; in Day, a day; in Year, a year.
Jump to today	Today (top right of the calendar), the Today item in the side menu, or Ctrl + T.
Look back at random	Surprise me or Ctrl + R jumps to a random entry from the past. Private entries are never chosen.
Change view	The Year / Month / Week / Day switch, or Ctrl + 1 (Day), 2 (Week), 3 (Month), 4 (Year).

Dragging entries

To move an entry to another day, press on its chip and drag it onto the day you want; a teal outline shows where it will land. The time of day is kept. In Day view you can drag an entry to another *hour* to change its time. Press Esc to cancel a drag.

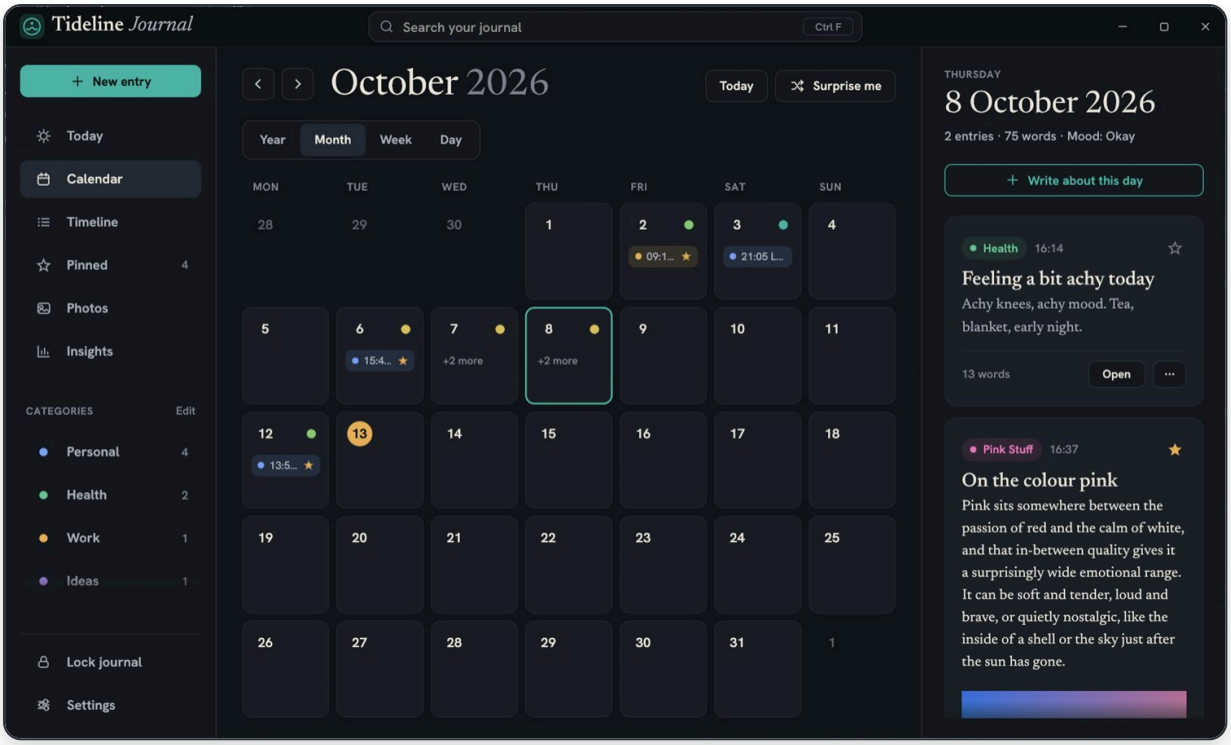
Starting an entry from the calendar

Double-click a day to write a new entry for it, or double-click an entry's chip to edit that entry. In Day view, double-clicking an hour starts an entry at that time.

CHAPTER 3

The day panel

The panel on the right is your reading view for the selected day.



The day panel. The second card has been opened with “Show more”.

The top of the panel

- The **weekday and date**, then a summary such as “2 entries · 75 words · Mood: Okay”.
- `Write about this day` starts a new entry for the selected day.
- `Summarise` appears when the optional AI helpers are switched on and the day has entries (see chapter 15).
- If you set a **daily word goal** (**Settings → Writing**), a thin progress bar shows how close the day is.

Entry cards

Every entry is a card showing its **category**, the **time**, a **star** (click it to pin or unpin), the **title**, a few lines of text and the word count.

- `Open` opens the entry in the writing view so you can read it in full or change it.
- The `···` button has `Delete` and, for a private entry that is showing, `Hide again`.
- **Show more** appears when an entry is longer than the preview, has several paragraphs or contains a picture (it then reads “Show more, with picture”). Click it to read the whole entry inside the card, pictures included; click **Show less** to fold it up again.
- Attached files are listed on the card with `Save as...` and `Open`.

Deleting and undoing

Deleting an entry moves it to **Recently deleted** (see chapter 13). A message appears at the top of the panel with an `Undo` button for the one you just removed.

Private entries

A private entry is shown as grey placeholder lines and “Private entry – click to show”. Click it to read it. It hides itself again when you lock the journal or leave the window.

Days with no entries

An empty day shows a dashed box that says “A blank page.”

On this day

Underneath the cards, “On this day” lists what you wrote on the same date in earlier years. Click one to jump to it.

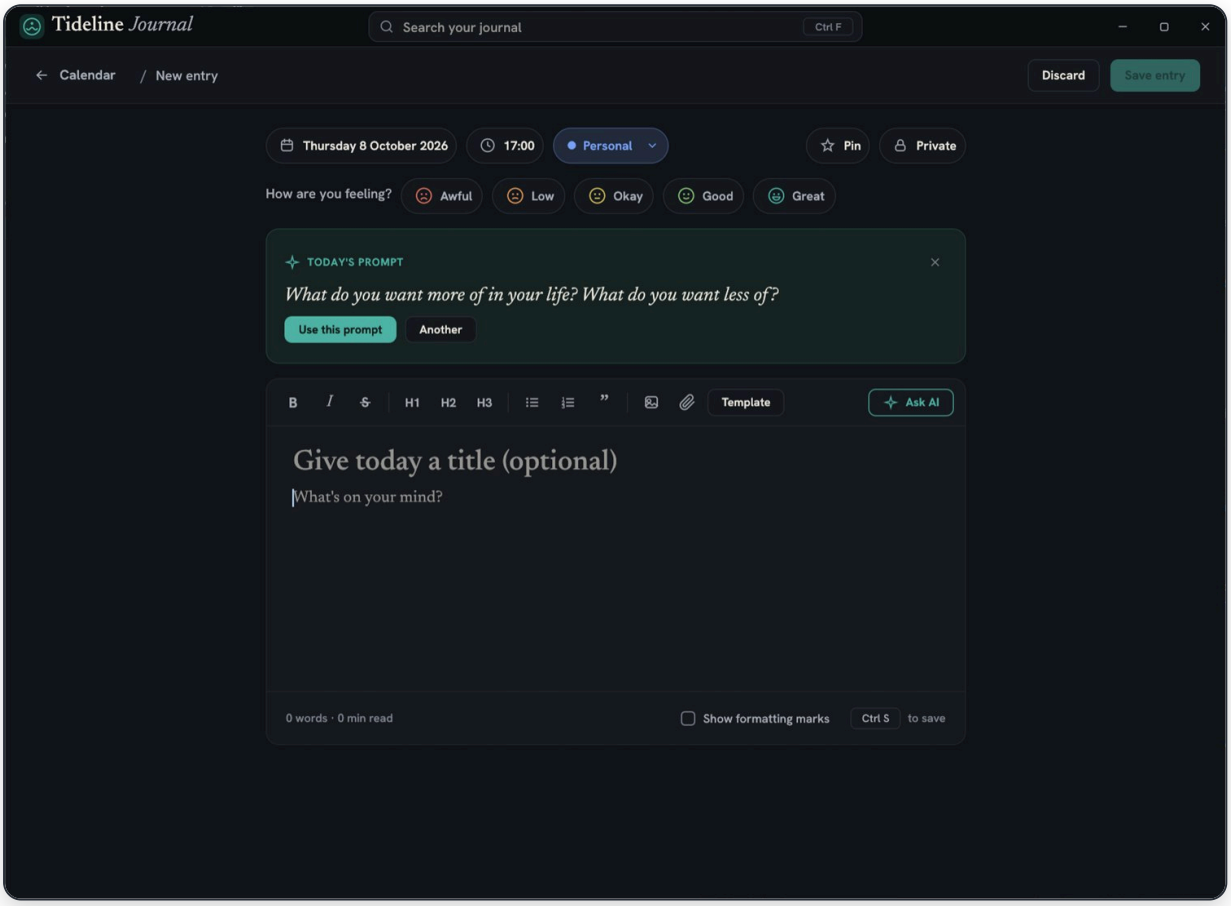
CHAPTER 4

Writing an entry

Writing has a whole page to itself, so there is nothing in the way.

Opening the writing page

There are several ways in: **New entry** in the side menu, **Write about this day**, Ctrl + N, double-clicking a day, or **Open** on an existing entry. A new entry belongs to the selected day and takes the current time.



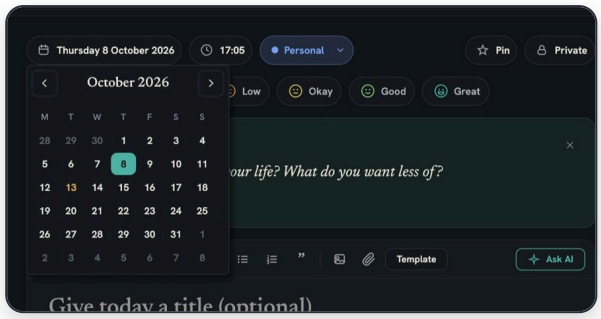
A new entry: details, mood, a prompt, and the writing card.

At the top, ← **Calendar** takes you back, **Discard** throws the entry away, and **Save entry** saves it. “Unsaved draft” tells you there are changes that are not saved yet.

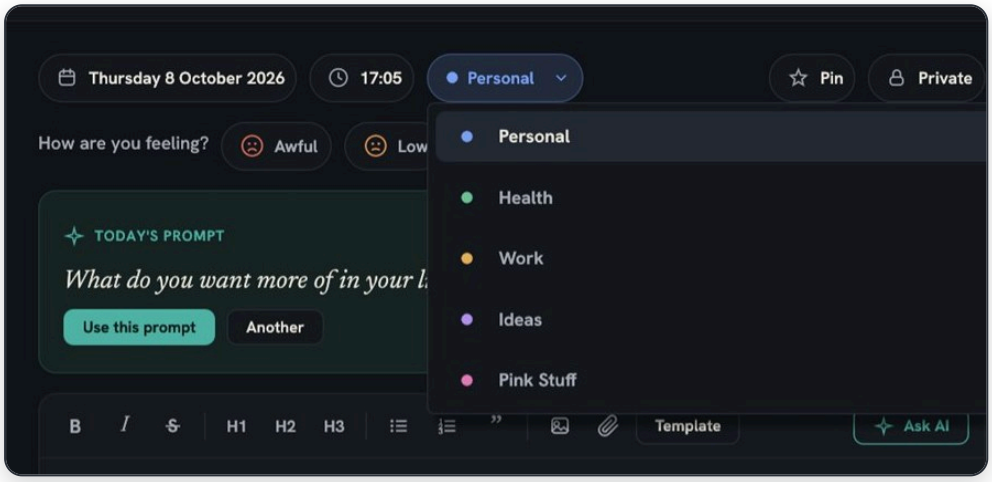
Date, time and category

The three chips at the top left set when the entry belongs and what it is about.

- **Date**: click the chip to open a small calendar and pick any day.
- **Time**: click the chip, then use the hour and minute boxes or press Now.
- **Category**: click the chip and choose from your categories.



The date picker.



Choosing a category.

On the right, Pin stars the entry so it appears under Pinned, and Private hides it until you click it (see chapter 12). Both are switches: click again to turn them off.

Mood

Under "How are you feeling?" choose one of five moods: **Awful, Low, Okay, Good** or **Great**. The chosen mood glows in its colour. Click it again to clear it. Moods feed the dots on the calendar and the charts in Insights, but they are entirely optional.

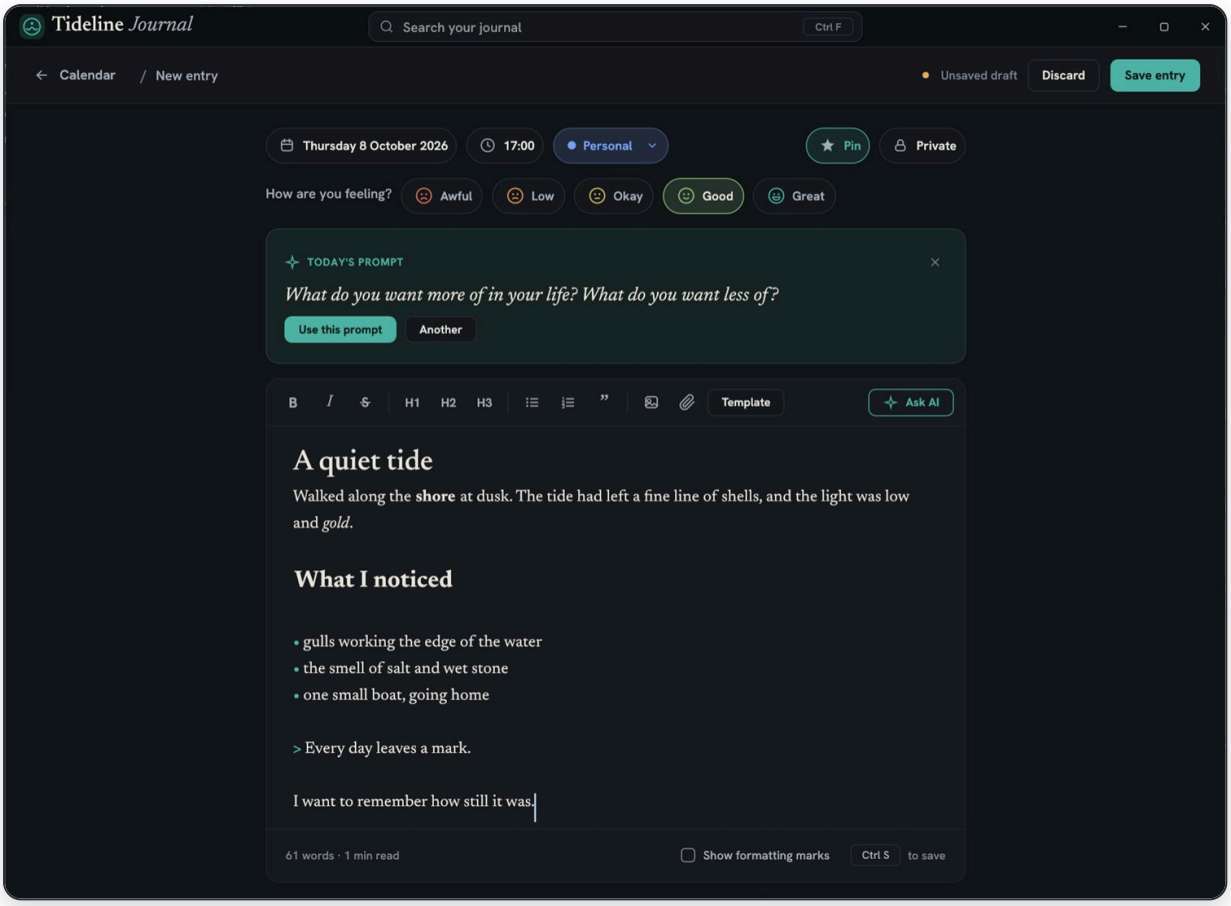
Writing prompts

The green card offers a question to get you started, such as "What do you want more of in your life?".

- Use this prompt puts the question into your entry as a heading **at the cursor**, on a line of its own, and leaves you ready to write the answer. Use it again, anywhere in the entry, for as many prompts as you like.
- Another shows a different question without adding anything.
- The × hides prompts. You can switch them back on under **Settings → Writing → Writing prompts**.

The card stays visible while you write, so you can pick a new prompt halfway through an entry.

The writing card



An entry in progress: a title, formatted text, a list and a quote.

Type an optional **title** at the top (press Enter to move into the text), then write below it. What you see is what you get: bold looks bold, headings are large, lists have bullets. Underneath, a line shows the word count and an estimated reading time.

The toolbar

BUTTON	WHAT IT DOES
B *I* ~~S~~	Bold, italic and strikethrough for the selected text. Click again to remove it. Ctrl + B and Ctrl + I work too. With nothing selected, the format starts at the cursor and applies to what you type next.
H1 H2 H3	Turn the line into a large, medium or small heading. Click again to turn it back into a normal paragraph.
▪ list, 1. list	Make the selected lines a bulleted or numbered list.
” quote	Make the selected lines a quotation.
Picture	Add a picture (see below).
Paperclip	Attach a file (see below).
Template	Fill the page from a template (see below).
Ask AI	Optional AI helpers (see chapter 15).

You can also type formatting as you go: `**bold**`, `*italic*`, `## Heading`, `- item` and `> quote` all work, and are shown formatted straight away.

> **FORMATTING MARKS**
> The little symbols behind formatting (such as the stars around bold text) are hidden so the page looks clean. The arrow keys, Backspace and Delete step over them as if they were not there. If you want to see them, tick **Show formatting marks** at the bottom of the card.

Pictures

Press the picture button and choose an image, or simply **drag an image file onto the window**. It appears in the text where your cursor was. A Remove picture button sits under each one. Large images are shrunk to a sensible size (1,600 pixels on the longest side) and stored inside your encrypted journal. Because pictures are part of the journal file, many large pictures make it bigger and saving slower.

Attachments

Press the paperclip to attach any file, up to **25 MB** each, or drag a file onto the window. Attached files are listed under the card with a Remove button, and are stored inside the encrypted journal. On a day’s card you can Save as... a copy or Open it.

GOOD TO KNOW

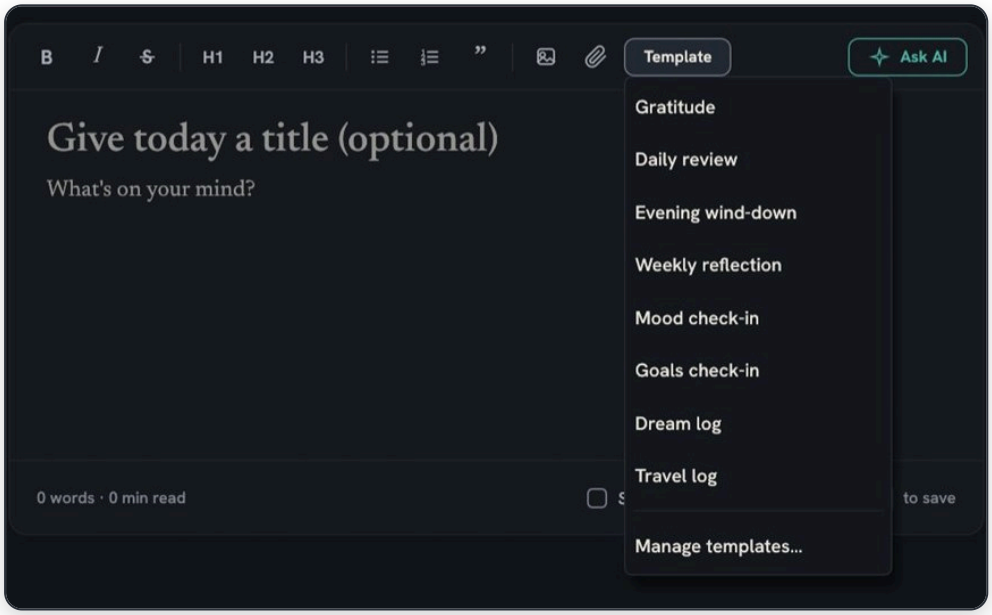
Open makes a temporary plain copy so another program can show it. The copy is kept in a folder beside your journal (`opened-attachments-temporary`) and removed when you lock the journal or next start the program.

FOR YOUR SAFETY

Programs and scripts (such as `.exe`, `.bat`, `.ps1`, `.vbs`, `.msi` and `.lnk` files) can be attached and saved as a copy, but they are **never opened** from the journal, so a file in a journal someone else gave you cannot start a program on your PC. Such a file shows "can't be opened here" instead of an **Open** button.

Templates

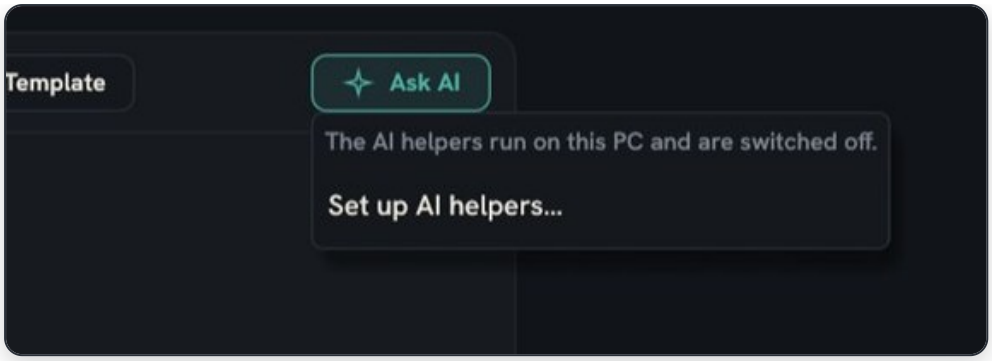
Press **Template** and choose one to fill the page with headings and questions to answer. **Manage templates…** opens the templates window (see chapter 10).



The Template menu.

Ask AI

Ask AI opens a menu. If the helpers are not set up, it offers **Set up AI helpers…**. Once they are on, it offers to turn your rough notes into an entry and to suggest a question to think about (see chapter 15).



The Ask AI menu before the helpers are set up.

Saving, discarding and word goals

- **Save** with Save entry, Ctrl + S or Ctrl + Enter. The journal is encrypted and written to disk each time.
- **Discard** or ← **Calendar** leaves without saving. If you have written something, the first click turns the button into “Click again to discard”, so you can’t lose work by accident; clicking anywhere else cancels it.
- With a **daily word goal** set, “Today so far” under the card shows progress for the whole day, counting this entry and the day’s other entries.
- Ctrl + D pins or unpins the entry while you write.

Changing or deleting an entry later

Press Open on its card, or double-click its chip. You can change anything, including its date, time, category, mood and pictures. To delete it, use ··· → Delete on its card.

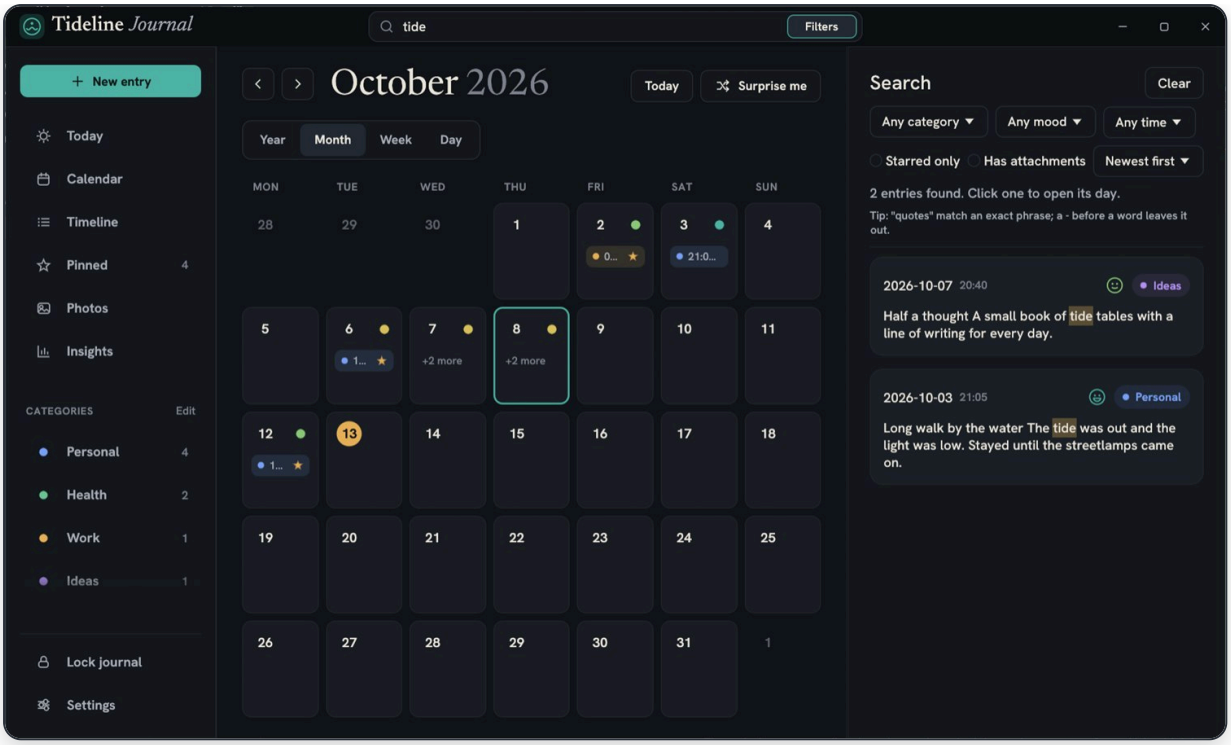
CHAPTER 5

Finding things

Search the whole journal in a moment, or browse everything newest first.

Search

Click the search box at the top (or press Ctrl + F) and start typing. The day panel is replaced by the results as you type, and matching words are highlighted. Click a result to jump to its day.



Searching for “tide”, with the filters showing.

YOU TYPE	IT FINDS
river walk	Entries containing *both* words, in any order and any capitals.
"river walk"	Entries with that exact phrase.
river -work	Entries with “river” but not “work”.

Search also looks at category names, dates (such as `2026-10`) and attachment file names. **Private entries are never found by their text**; they can only turn up by category or date.

Filters

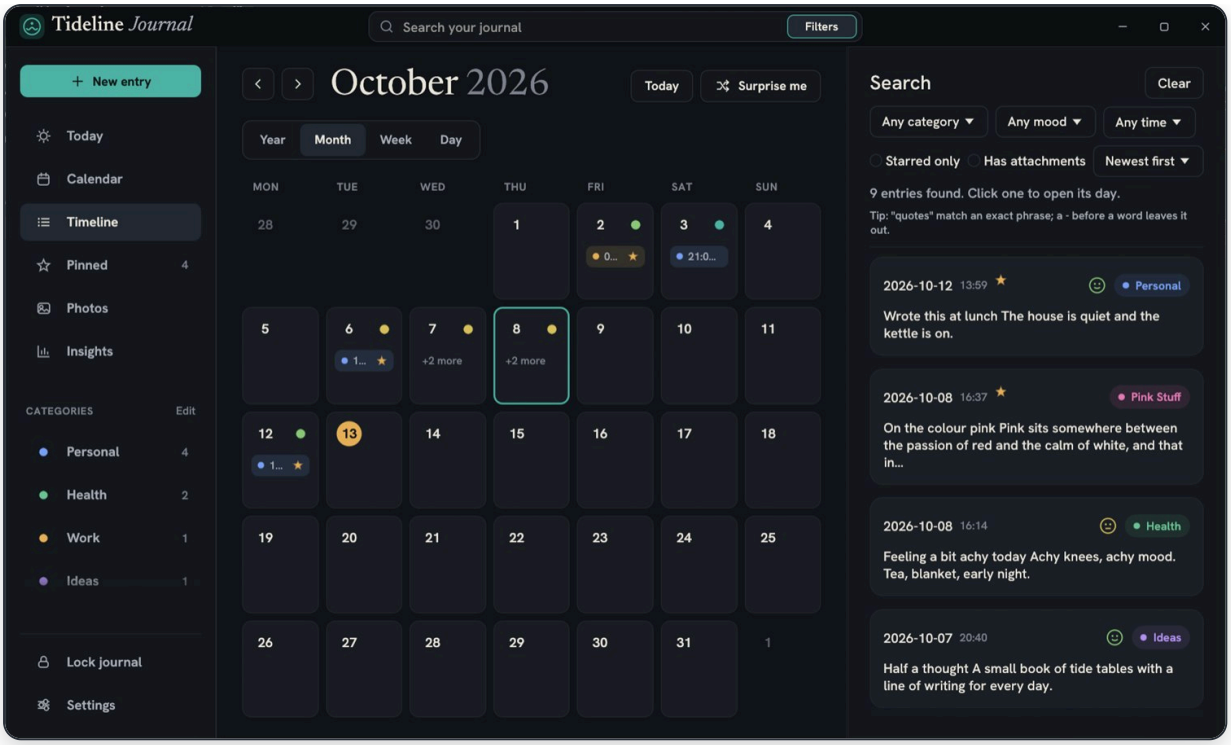
Press **Filters** in the search box, or just start with the filters and no words at all. You can narrow results by:

- **Category** and **Mood**,
- **Time**: any time, the last 7 or 30 days, the last year, or “Between dates…”,
- **Starred only** and **Has attachments**,
- and sort by **Newest first**, **Oldest first** or **Best match**.

Clear (top right of the results) empties the search and the filters and returns to the day view.

Timeline

Timeline in the side menu lists every entry, newest first, in the same results panel. It is the quickest way to scroll back through everything.



The Timeline.

Categories in the side menu

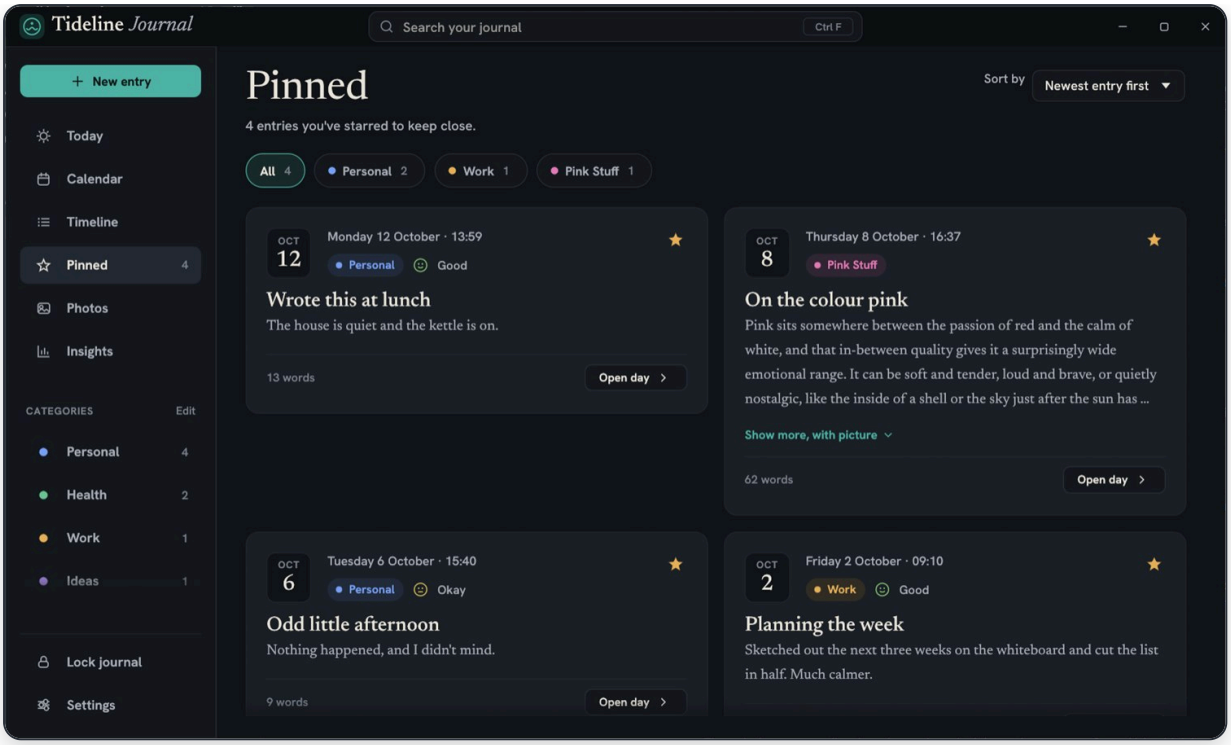
Each category in the side menu shows how many entries it holds. Click one to see only that category's entries. **Edit** next to "Categories" opens the category editor (see chapter 9).

CHAPTER 6

Pinned

Star the entries you want to be able to find again in a second.

Pin an entry by clicking the star on its card, using the **Pin** switch while writing, or pressing Ctrl + D in the writing page. Pinned entries carry a star on the calendar. **Pinned** in the side menu opens them all on one page.



The Pinned page.

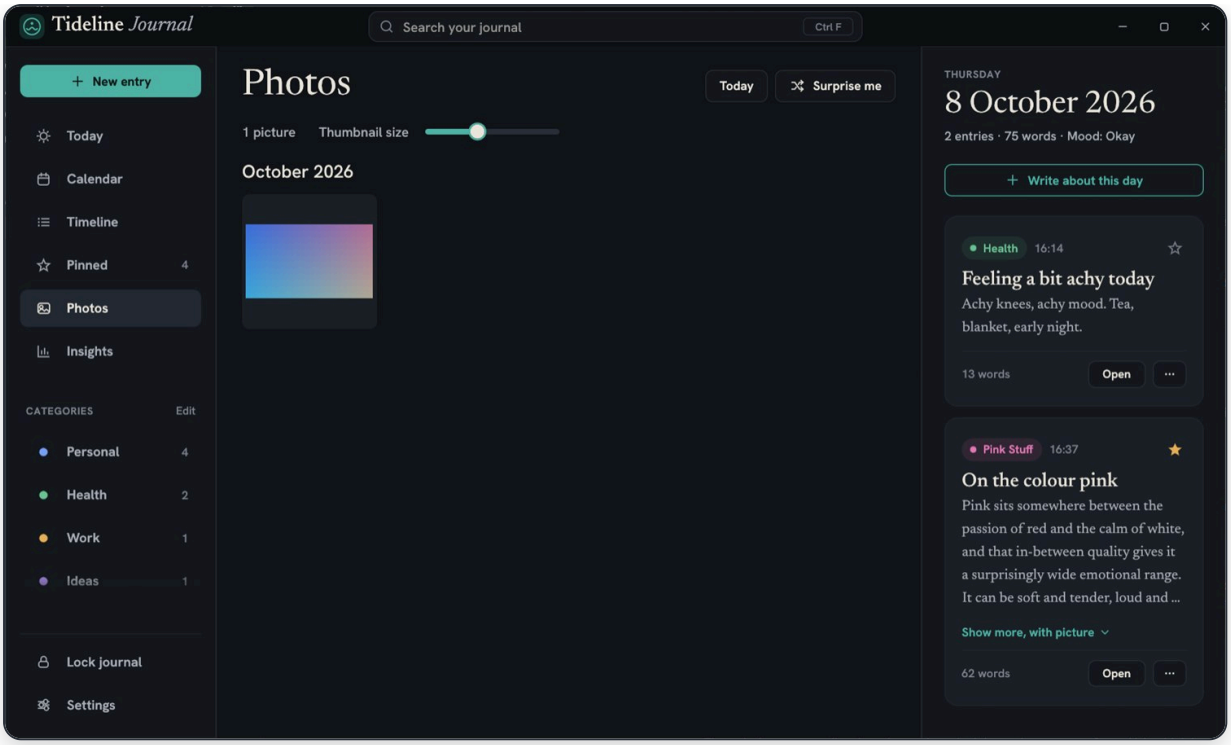
- Each card shows a date tile, the day and time, the category, the mood, the title and a short preview with the word count.
- **Show more** opens the whole entry in the card, pictures included.
- Open day takes you to that day on the calendar.
- Click a card's **star** to unpin it.
- The chips at the top (**All**, then one per category) filter the cards, and **Sort by** orders them by newest, oldest or longest.
- The dashed card at the end reminds you how to pin more.

CHAPTER 7

Photos

Every picture you have added, in one place.

Photos in the side menu shows all the pictures in your journal as thumbnails, newest first, grouped by month.



The Photos page, with the thumbnail-size slider.

- Drag the **Thumbnail size** slider to make the pictures smaller or bigger.
- Click a picture to see it large. The arrow keys move between pictures, and from the viewer you can jump to the entry the picture belongs to.
- Pictures from private entries are marked, and the entry they belong to stays hidden until you reveal it.

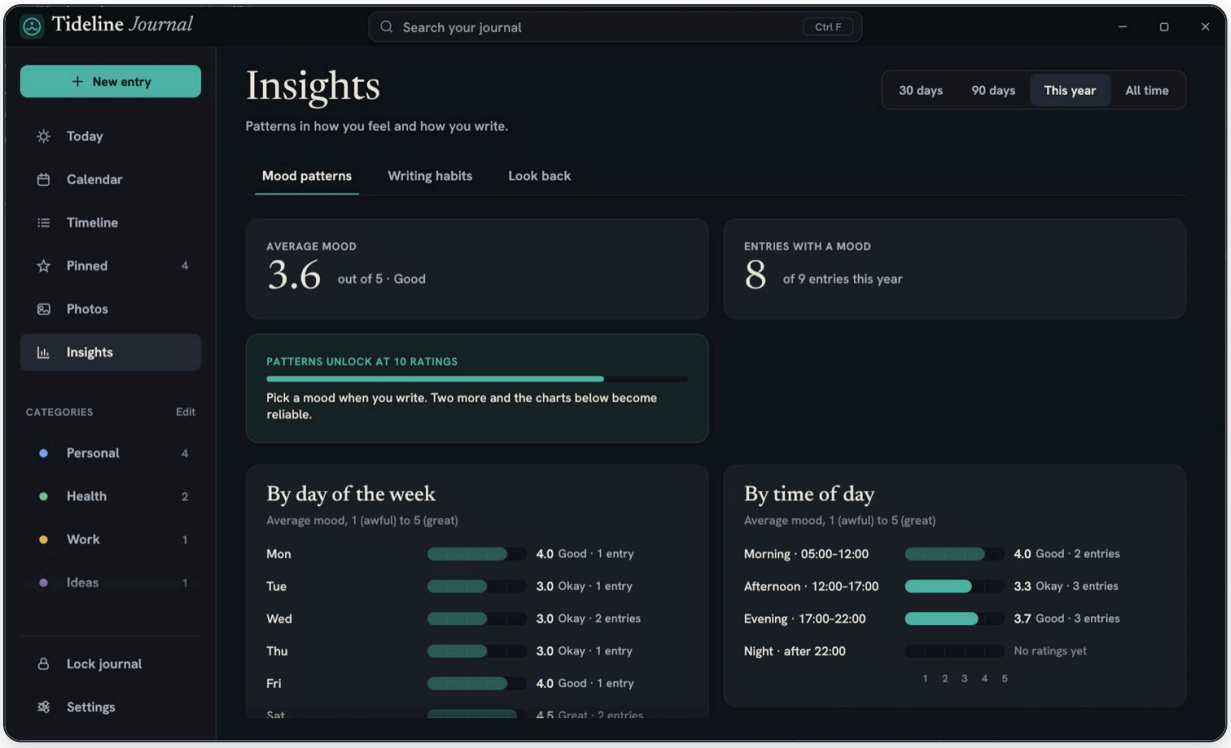
CHAPTER 8

Insights

Patterns in how you feel and how you write, worked out from your own entries and shown only to you.

Choose **Insights** in the side menu. At the top right, switch the range between **30 days**, **90 days**, **This year** and **All time**. There are three tabs.

Mood patterns

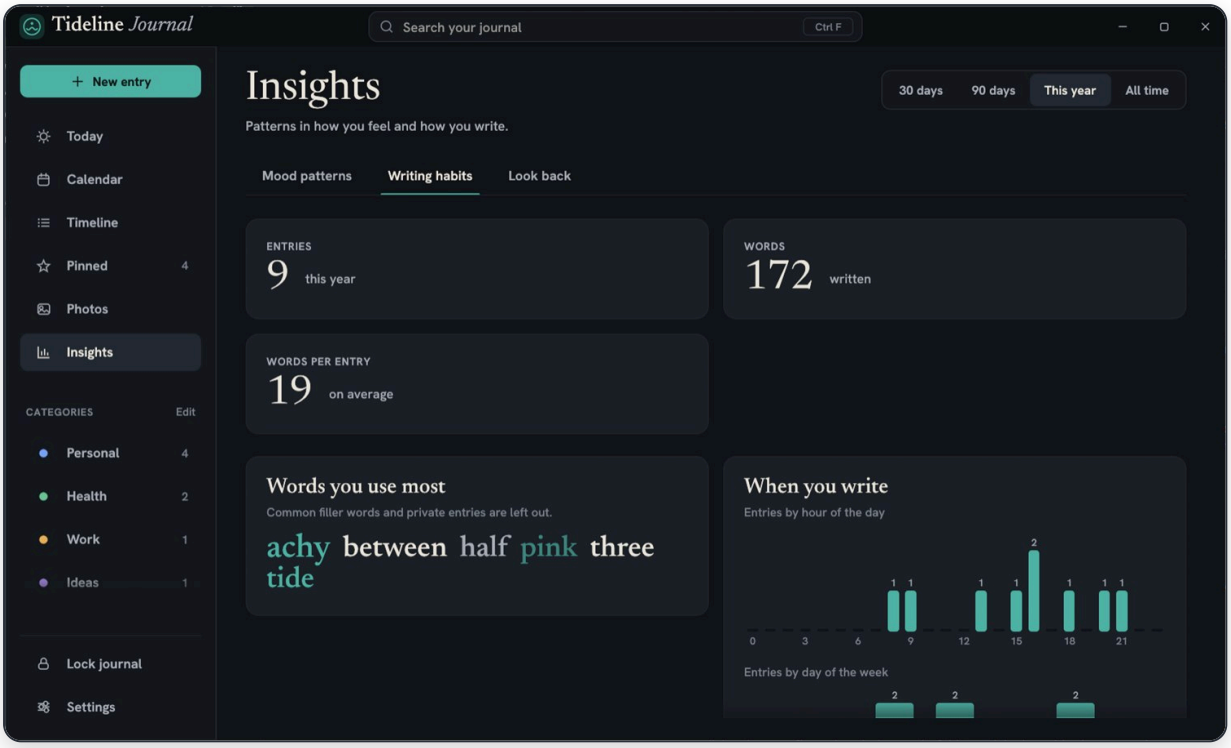


Mood patterns for the year.

- **Average mood** and **Entries with a mood** sum up the range.
- The green card shows how many ratings you need before the charts are reliable. Once you have ten, it lists plain-language observations instead, such as which time of day you tend to feel best.
- The bar charts show your average mood **by day of the week, time of day, length of entry** and **category**. The scale along the bottom runs from 1 (awful) to 5 (great). A **dimmer bar** means fewer than three entries, so it is only an early signal.
- **View as table** (below the charts) shows the same numbers as a table.

> **REMEMBER**
>
> These are patterns in your own ratings, not causes. A quiet bar may simply mean you rarely wrote at that time.

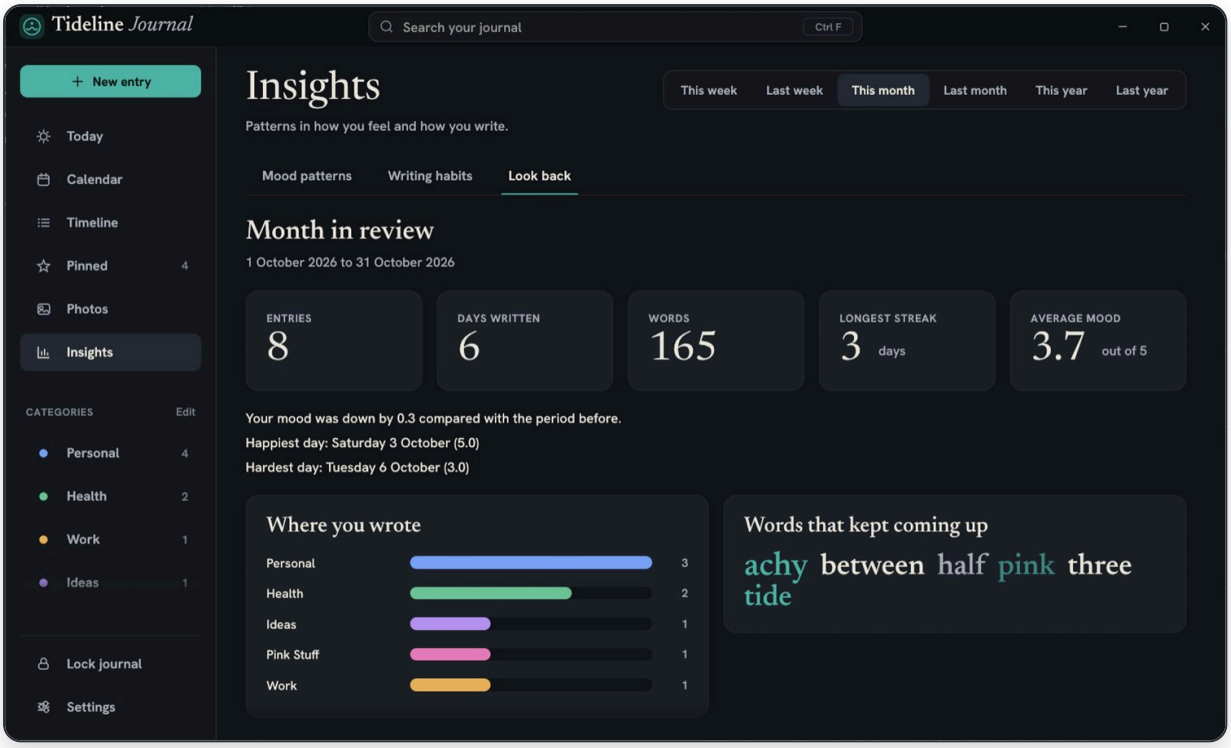
Writing habits



Writing habits.

Totals for entries, words and words per entry; the words you use most (bigger means more often; everyday filler words and private entries are left out); charts of when you write by hour of the day and day of the week; and your longest entries (click one to jump to it).

Look back



A month in review.

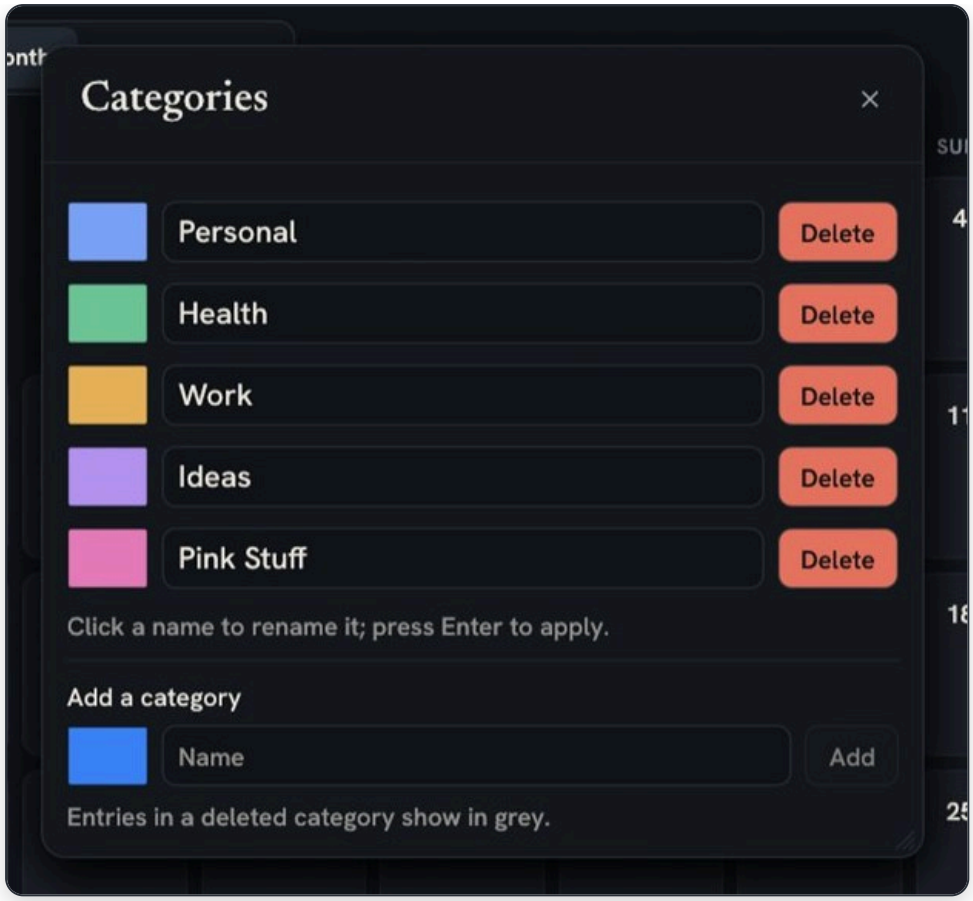
A recap of a week, month or year: choose **This week, Last week, This month, Last month, This year** or **Last year** at the top right. You get your totals, how your mood compared with the period before, your happiest and hardest days, where you wrote, words that kept coming up, pictures from the period, and entries to remember. Save this review as a PDF… at the bottom makes a printable copy.

CHAPTER 9

Categories

Categories are the coloured labels that say what an entry is about.

Open the editor with Edit next to “Categories” in the side menu.



The Categories window.

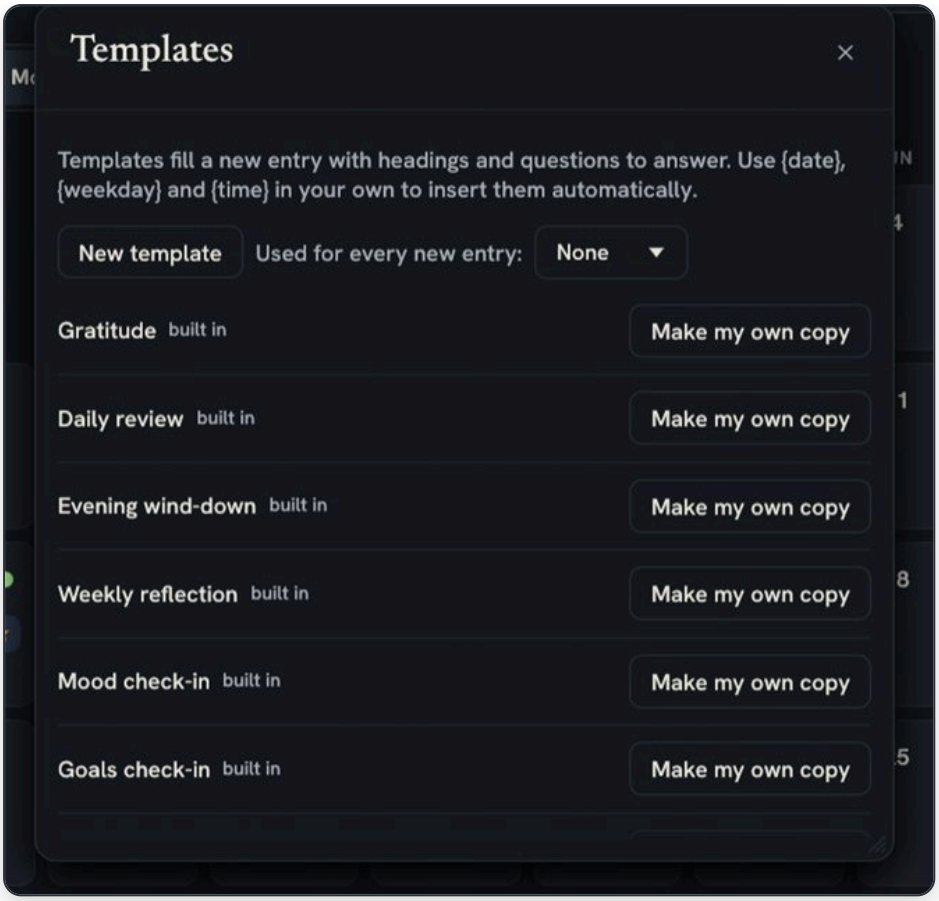
- **Rename**: click a name, type the new one and press `Enter`. Every entry using that category is updated.
- **Change the colour**: click the coloured square next to a name and pick a colour.
- **Add**: type a name under “Add a category”, choose a colour and press `Add`.
- **Delete**: press `Delete` next to a name. The category goes, but its entries are kept and shown in grey.

CHAPTER 10

Templates

A template fills a new entry with headings and questions, so you never start from a blank page unless you want to.

Open the templates window from **Settings → Writing → Templates → Manage**, or from the `Template` menu in the writing page.



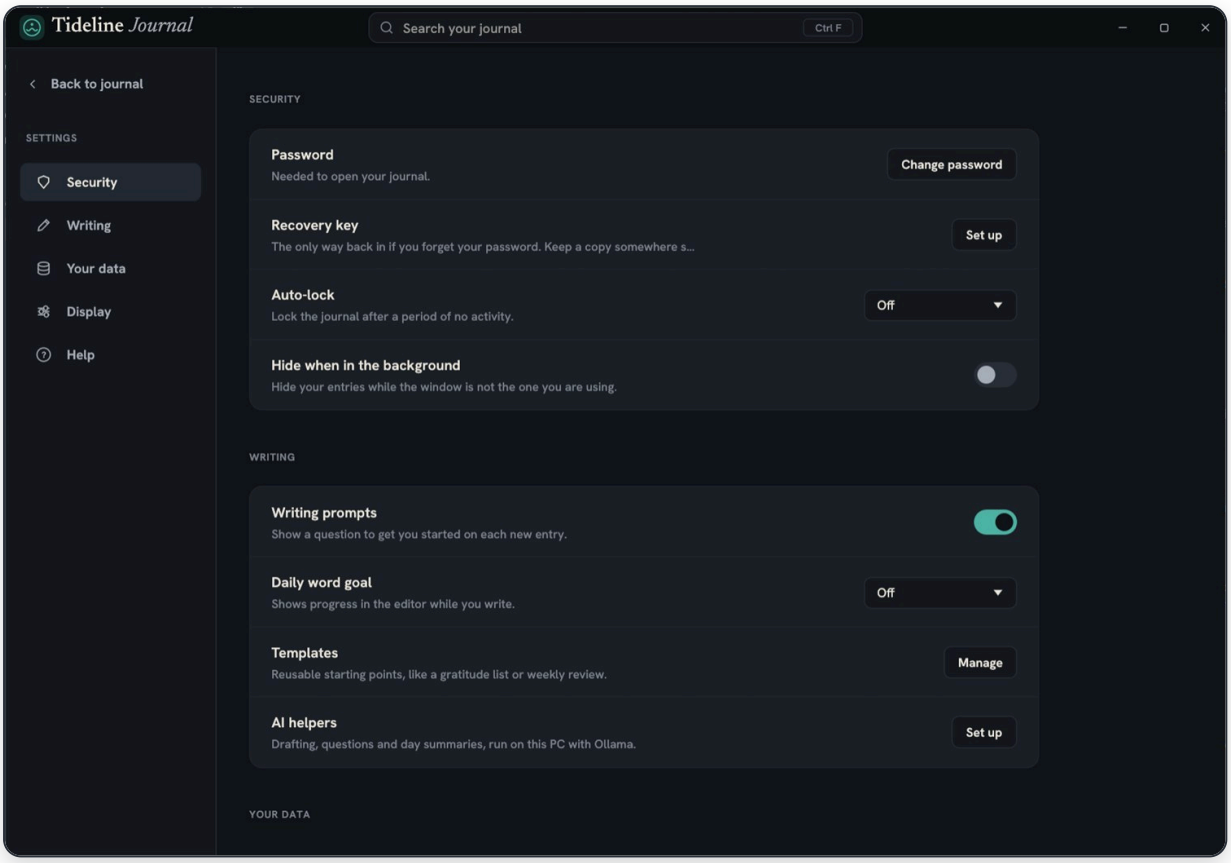
The Templates window.

- **Eight built-in templates**: Gratitude, Daily review, Evening wind-down, Weekly reflection, Mood check-in, Goals check-in, Dream log and Travel log.
- Built-in templates cannot be changed. Press **Make my own copy** to get an editable version.
- **New template** starts one from scratch. Give it a name and write its text. You can use `{date}`, `{weekday}` and `{time}`, which are replaced automatically when the template is used.
- **Used for every new entry** lets you choose a template that is filled in each time you start a new entry (or "None").

CHAPTER 11

Settings

Choose **Settings** at the bottom of the side menu. Changes are saved as you make them.



The Settings page. The left column jumps to each section.

‹ Back to journal returns to the calendar. Each row has a title, a line of explanation and its control on the right.

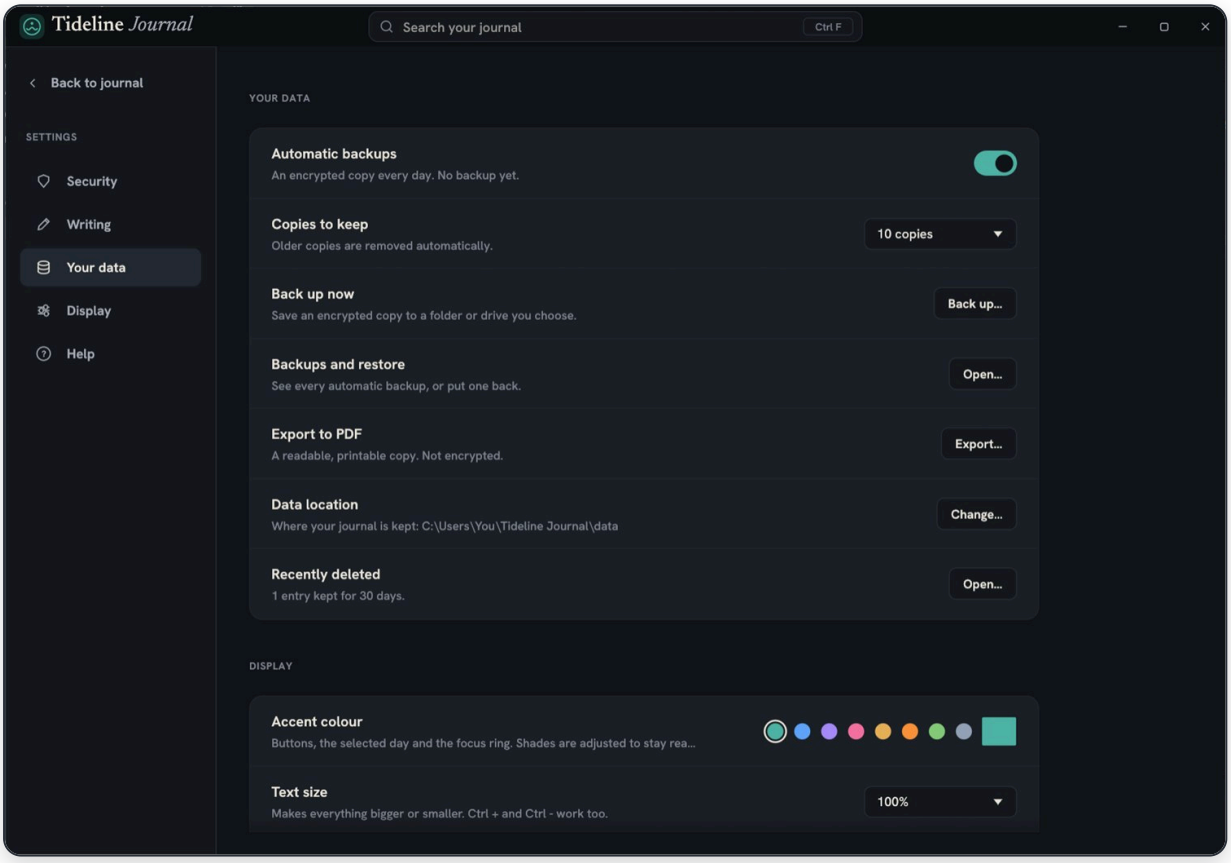
Security

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Password	**Change password** opens a window to choose a new one (at least 8 characters).
Recovery key	Creates, shows or replaces the key that can open your journal if you forget your password (see chapter 12).
Auto-lock	Locks the journal after no activity for: Off, 1, 5, 10 (the default) or 30 minutes.
Hide when in the background	Blanks the window while you are using another program or it is minimised.

Writing

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Writing prompts	Shows or hides the prompt card in the writing page.
Daily word goal	Off, 100, 250, 500, 750 or 1,000 words. Progress shows on the day panel and in the writing page.
Templates	**Manage** opens the templates window.
AI helpers	**Set up** (or **Manage**) opens the optional helpers (see chapter 15).

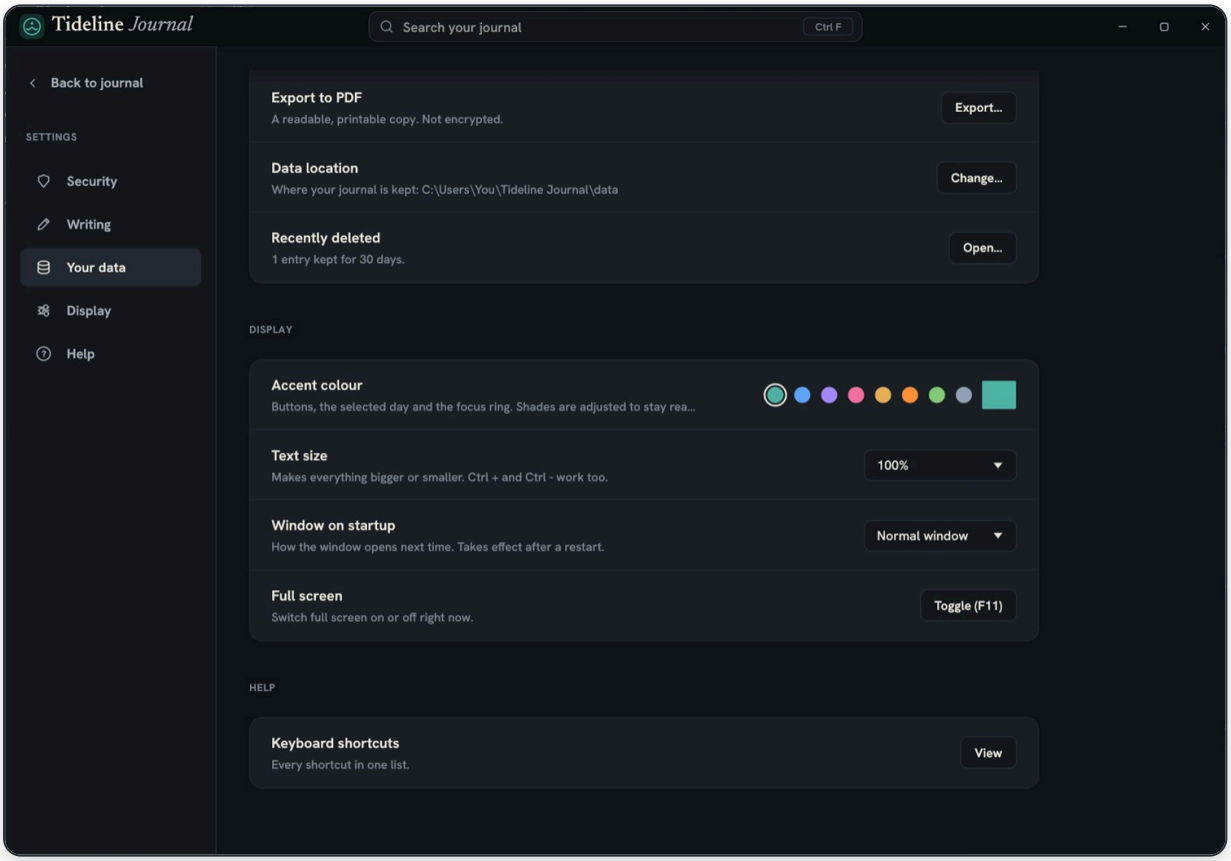
Your data



The Your data and Display sections.

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Automatic backups	Switches the daily encrypted copy on or off, and shows the date of the last one.
Copies to keep	How many automatic backups to keep: 5, 10, 20, 30 or 60. Older ones are removed.
Back up now	**Back up…** saves an encrypted copy wherever you choose, such as a USB drive.
Backups and restore	Opens the list of automatic backups, where you can restore or delete one.
Export to PDF	Makes a readable, printable copy of some or all entries (not encrypted).
Data location	Shows where the journal is stored, and lets you move it or open one from another folder.
Recently deleted	The 30-day bin for deleted entries.

Display



Display and Help.

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Accent colour	The one colour you can change. Pick one of eight (Tide, Sky, Violet, Rose, Lamp, Ember, Moss, Slate) or press the colour square to choose any colour you like. It is used for buttons, the selected day and highlights, and is automatically adjusted so text always stays easy to read.
Text size	80% to 160%. `Ctrl` + `+`, `Ctrl` + `-` and `Ctrl` + `0` change it from anywhere.
Window on startup	Normal window, Maximised or Full screen. It takes effect the next time you start the program.
Full screen	**Toggle (F11)** switches full screen on or off right now.

Sync

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Sync	Optional. Sets up, shows and manages syncing with your phone through a server you run yourself (see chapter 14).

Help

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
User guide	Saves or opens this guide as a PDF.
Keyboard shortcuts	**View** lists every shortcut.
Privacy and security	**View** shows what is protected and what leaves this PC, with a link to the full page.

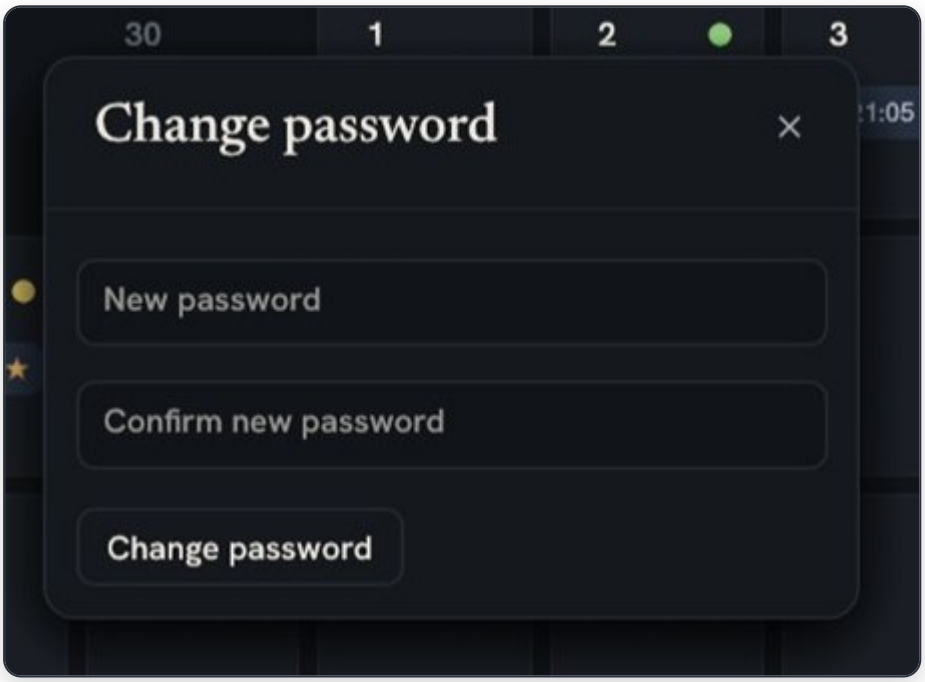
CHAPTER 12

Privacy and security

Your journal is encrypted on disk and goes nowhere unless you set up syncing. These are the tools that keep it private.

Your password

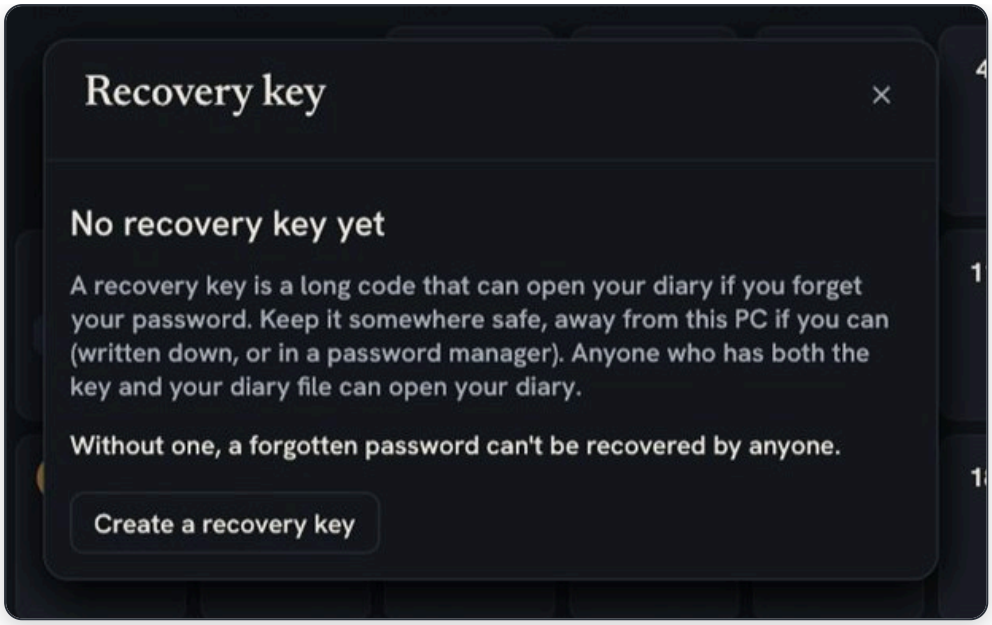
Your entries, pictures and files are sealed with strong encryption (XChaCha20-Poly1305) under a key that is itself protected by your password (Argon2id). Without the password, the file is unreadable noise. To change it, use **Settings → Security → Password → Change password**, type the new password twice and press `Change password`.



Changing the password.

The recovery key

A recovery key is a long code, shown once, that can open your journal if you forget your password. Open **Settings → Security → Recovery key**.



No recovery key yet.

1. Press **Create a recovery key**. The key appears *once* on the screen.
2. Press **Copy** or **Save as text file…** and keep it somewhere safe and **away from this PC**: written down, or in a password manager.
3. Tick "I have stored my recovery key somewhere safe", then press **Done**.

Later the same window lets you make a **new** key (the old one stops working) or **remove** the key. Each of these needs a second click to confirm.

If you forget your password

1. On the unlock screen choose **Forgot your password?**
2. Type your recovery key and choose a new password.
3. The journal opens, with the new password from now on.

> IMPORTANT
> Anyone who has both your recovery key and your journal file can open your journal, so keep the key private. If you have no recovery key and forget your password, the journal cannot be recovered by anyone.

Private entries

Switch on **Private** while writing and the entry is hidden until you click it. While hidden, its text, mood, pictures and search matches are not shown. It hides again when you lock the journal or leave the window. Private entries are also left out of searches by text, **Surprise me**, Insights, PDF exports (unless you ask for them) and the AI helpers.

Auto-lock and hiding in the background

Auto-lock locks the journal after a period of no activity (10 minutes unless you change it). **Hide when in the background** blanks the whole window as soon as you switch to another program or minimise it, so no one can read it over your shoulder when you step away. Click the window to show it again.

What is and isn't protected

- The journal file and its automatic backups are **encrypted**.
- **PDF exports are not encrypted.** They are a plain copy of what you chose, so keep them somewhere safe.
- While the journal is unlocked, the decrypted text is in the computer's memory. Lock it when you step away.
- Nothing is sent anywhere unless you turn on syncing, and then only encrypted data goes to the server you run yourself. The optional AI helpers talk only to a program running on your own PC. **Settings → Help → Privacy and security** shows the short version, and the full page (what the sync server can and can't see, the limits and the technical details) is `PRIVACY.md` in the program's project folder on GitHub.

CHAPTER 13

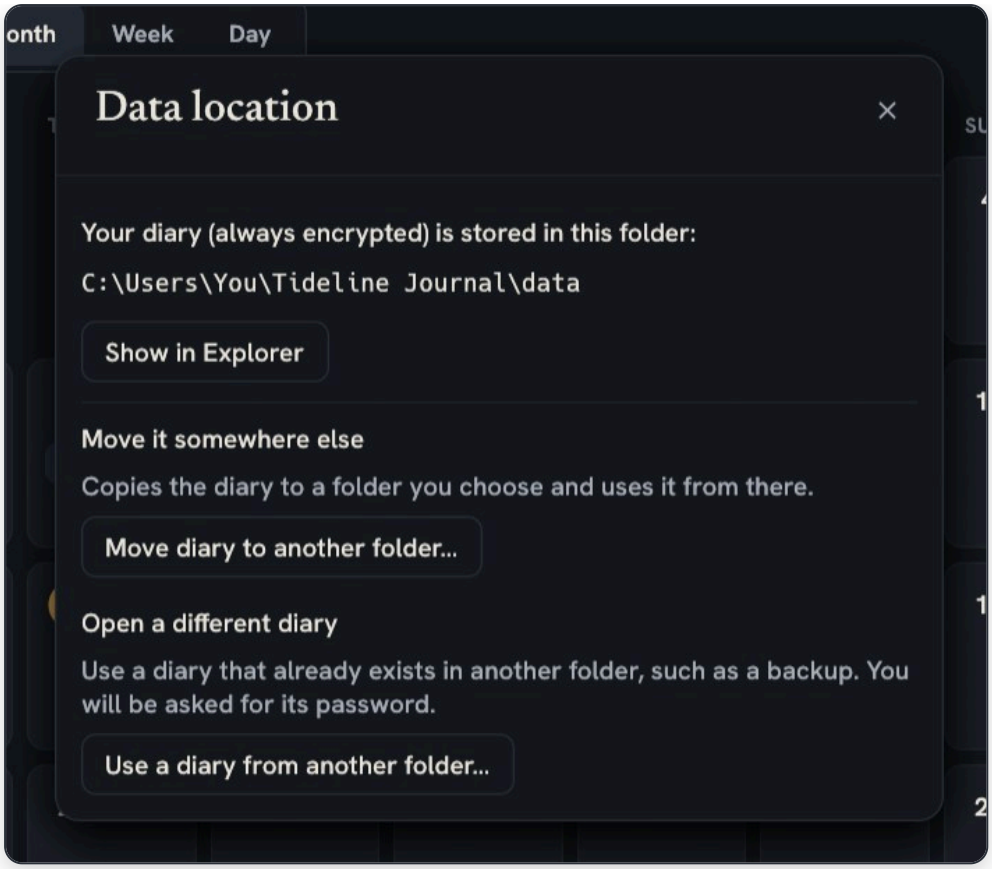
Your data

Where your journal lives, how to back it up and how to get things back.

Where your journal is stored

By default your journal is in a folder called `data` beside the program. Inside it are `entries.json` (your encrypted journal), `backups` (automatic copies) and `config.json` (a few settings that are needed before you unlock). The folder is easy to find and copy.

Open **Settings → Your data → Data location → Change…** to see exactly where it is.



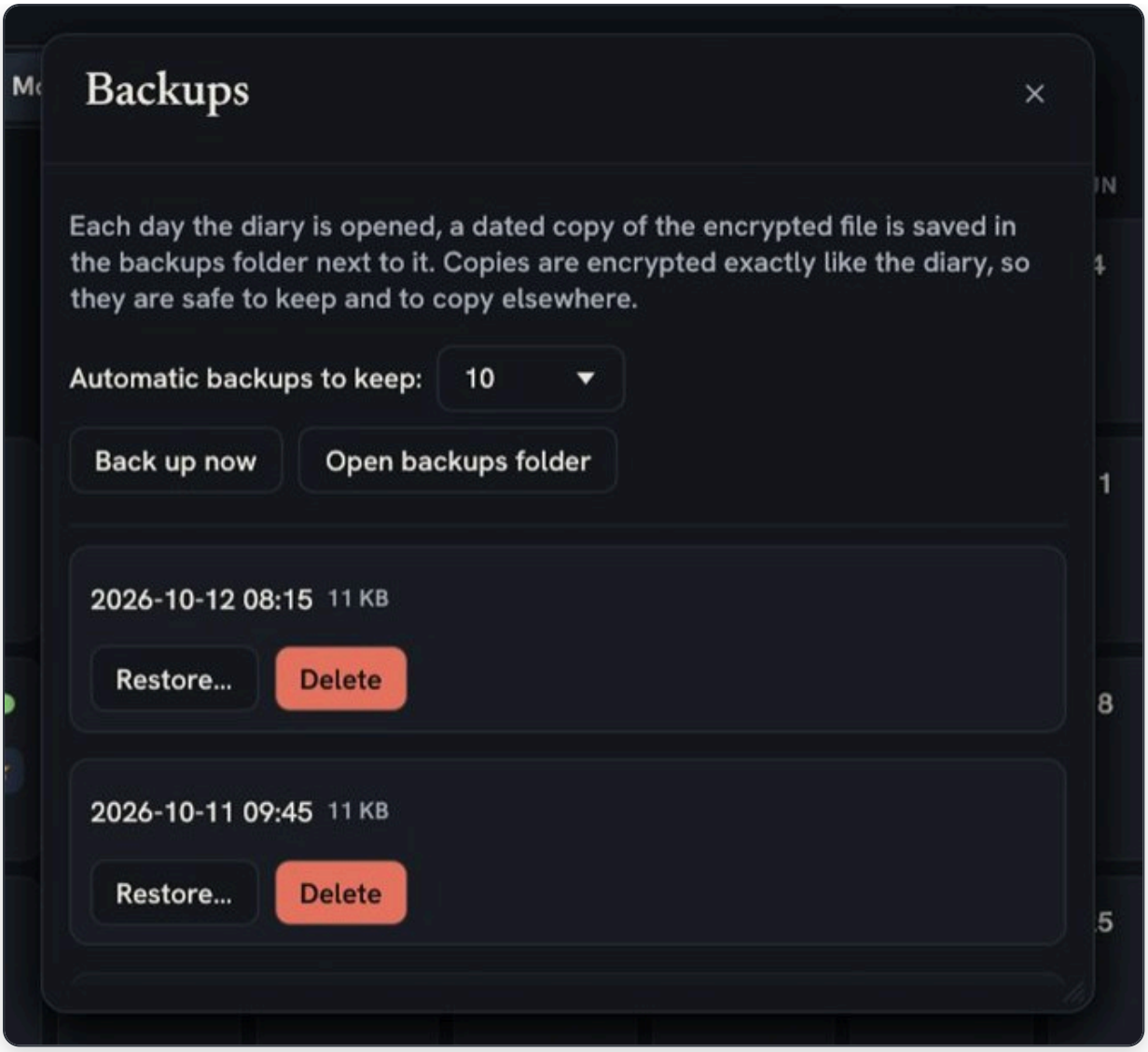
The Data location window.

- **Show in Explorer** opens the folder.
- **Move diary to another folder...** copies your journal to a folder you choose and uses it from there.
- **Use a diary from another folder...** opens a journal that already exists elsewhere, such as a backup. You will be asked for its password.

Automatic backups

The first time you open the journal each day, and only if it has changed, a dated copy of the encrypted file is saved in the `backups` folder. They are encrypted exactly like your journal, so they are safe to keep and to copy elsewhere. Choose how many to keep under **Settings → Your data** (the default is 10).

Settings → Your data → Backups and restore → Open... shows the list.



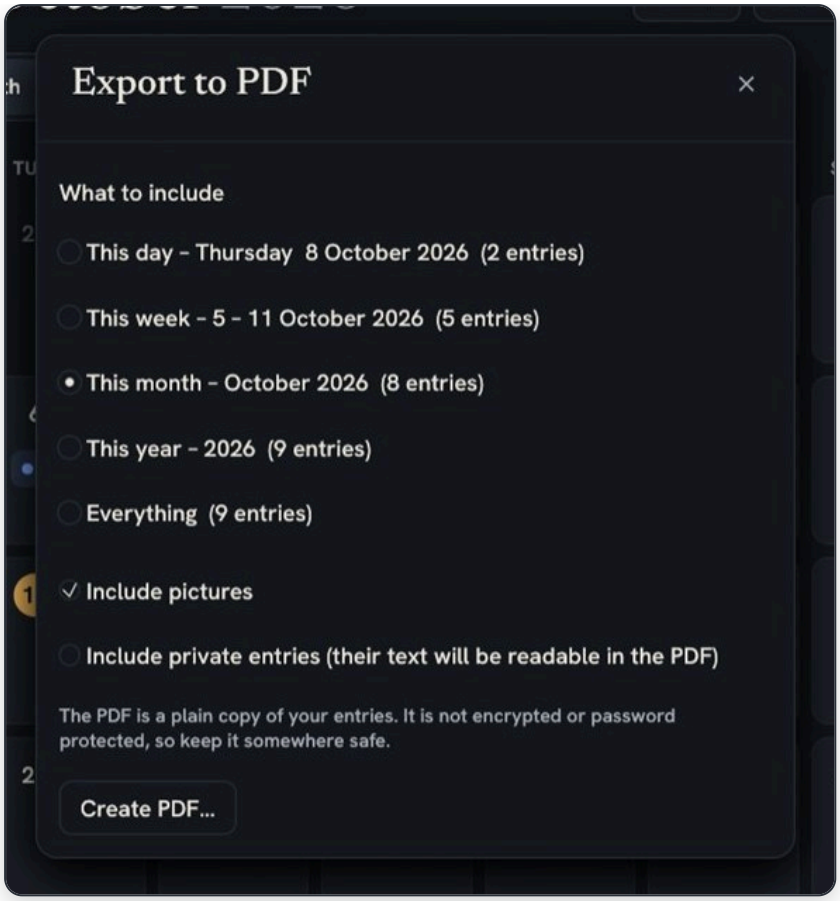
The Backups window.

- **Back up now** makes a copy straight away; **Open backups folder** shows the files.
- **Delete** removes one backup.
- **Restore...** puts a backup back in place. Click it a second time to confirm. Your current journal is first saved as a "before restore" safety copy, then the journal locks and you unlock it with the password **that backup had when it was made** (which may be an older password).

> **TIP**
> Automatic backups live next to the journal, so they won't help if the whole drive is lost. Use **Back up...** now and then to save a copy to a different drive.

Export to PDF

Settings → Your data → Export to PDF → Export... or `Ctrl` + `E` makes a printable PDF.



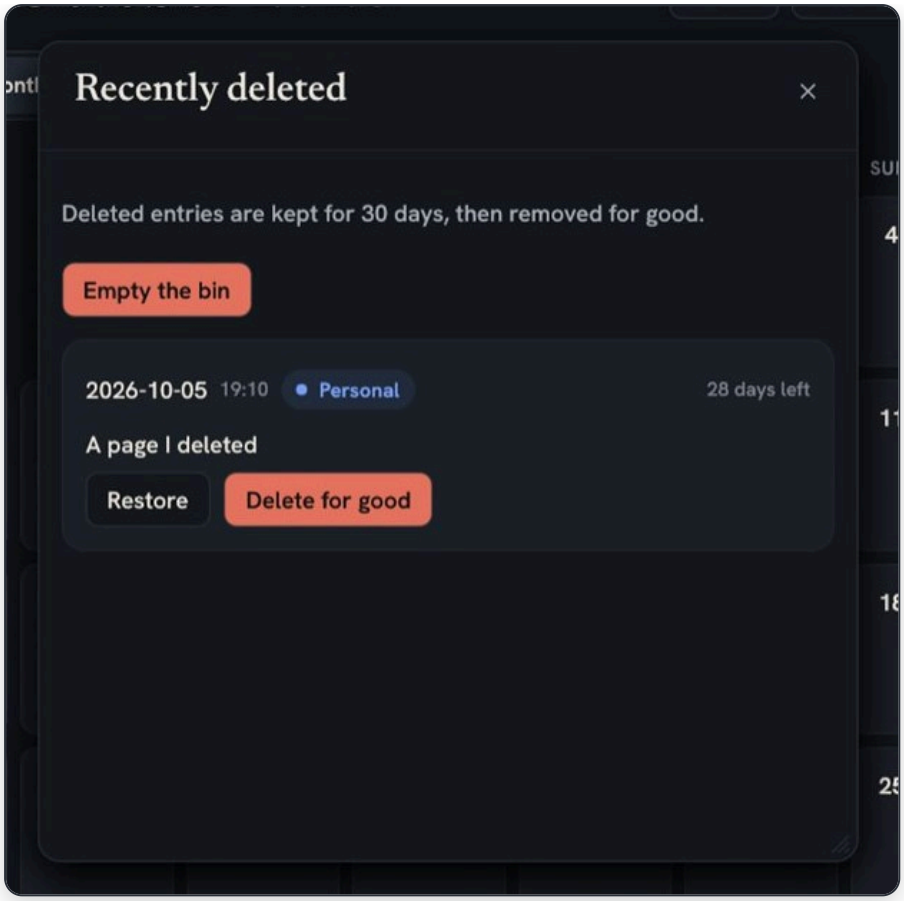
The Export window.

- Choose what to include: **this day, this week, this month, this year** or **everything** (each shows how many entries it holds).
- Tick or untick **Include pictures**.
- Private entries are left out unless you tick **Include private entries**.
- Press `Create PDF...` and choose where to save it.

> CAREFUL
>
> A PDF export is **not** encrypted or password protected. Keep it somewhere safe, and delete it when you no longer need it.

Recently deleted

Deleting an entry moves it here for **30 days**, then it is removed for good. Open it from **Settings → Your data → Recently deleted → Open...**.



Recently deleted.

- **Restore** puts an entry back on its day (with its pictures).
- **Delete for good** removes one permanently.
- **Empty the bin** removes everything. Click it a second time to confirm.

Taking your journal with you (portable use)

The program is a single file, `tideline-journal.exe`, and needs no installer. Copy it, together with the `data` folder, onto a USB drive and run it from there on any Windows PC: your journal stays on the drive.

- Use “Safely remove” before unplugging the drive.
- Files you open from entries are copied into the `data` folder (not onto the PC you are visiting) and removed when you lock.
- The program is not code-signed, so Windows may show “Windows protected your PC”. Choose **More info** → **Run anyway**. A PC with Smart App Control switched on may refuse unsigned programs entirely.

CHAPTER 14

Syncing with your phone

Optional. Keep the same journal on your PC and your phone, in step, without any company's cloud in between.

How it works

Syncing goes through a small **sync server** that you run yourself, for example on a PC or mini-computer at home. Every change is encrypted on your PC or phone *before* it is sent, using a key that comes from your journal password. The server only ever holds scrambled data: it cannot read your entries, your pictures or even the names of your categories.

- Syncing is **off** until you set it up, and nothing leaves your PC before then.
- The password is never sent anywhere. Each device needs it to open the journal.
- Your journal still works without the server. Changes wait and are sent when it can be reached again.

> **WHAT YOU NEED**
>
> The sync server program (`tideline-server`) running on a computer that both your PC and your phone can reach, normally on the same Wi-Fi. By default it listens on port **8787**. Its address looks like `192.168.1.20:8787`.

Setting up on your PC

Do this once, on the PC that holds your journal.

1. Open **Settings → Sync**.
2. Type a **Diary name** so you can tell what you are connected to, for example "Dave's Diary". It is optional but helpful.
3. Type the **Server address** and press **Set up sync**.
4. Your journal is sent to the server and the screen changes to show its progress. From now on it syncs by itself in the background, and **Sync now** does it straight away.

Setting up makes a **sync code**: a long secret that lets a device use your journal on the server. Anyone with the code can add to your synced data but cannot read it, so keep it private. To see it, open **Settings → Sync → Sync code → Manage…** and press **Show the code**.

Adding your phone

The easiest way is a QR code.

1. On the PC, open **Settings → Sync** and press **Show QR code**. It contains the server address, the sync code and the diary name, but **never your password**. Press **Hide** when you have finished.
2. On the phone, install the Tideline app and open it. On the first screen choose **Join a synced diary**, then **Scan QR code from your PC** and point the camera at the PC's screen. The first time, Android asks to allow the camera. It is used only for scanning.
3. The server address and code fill in. Type your journal's **password** and press **Join**. Your journal arrives on the phone.

If you would rather type, press **Copy details** on the PC, then enter the server address and sync code on the phone yourself.

> TIP
>
> A phone that already has its own journal can also connect to the server, from **Settings → Sync** in the phone app. But that connects the *phone's* journal, which is a different journal from the PC's. To bring the PC's journal onto a phone, start from the phone's first screen with **Join a synced diary**.

Using a synced diary on another PC

A PC can also join a diary that already exists on the server, for example one you started on your phone, or your journal on a second computer. You need the server address, the sync code and the diary's password.

1. On the device that has the diary, open **Settings → Sync** and press **Copy details**. Paste them somewhere you can read them on the PC (an email to yourself, a note), or read them across.
2. On the PC, choose **Join a synced diary…**. On a new PC this is on the first screen. On a PC that already has a diary, use **Settings → Sync → Join a synced diary → Join…** and confirm.
3. Type the server address and the sync code, then the diary's **password**, and press **Join**.
4. The PC makes an empty copy of the diary and brings every entry and picture across within a moment.

A diary that was already on this PC is **not deleted**. It is put in a `set-aside` folder inside the data folder. To get it back, use **Settings → Your data → Data location → Use a diary from another folder…** and choose that folder.

Day to day

- **On the PC** syncing runs quietly in the background. The top row of **Settings → Sync** shows the diary's name and when it last synced, with a **Sync now** button.
- **On the phone** it syncs about every 30 seconds while the app is open, and you can pull down on the main list to sync at once. **Settings → Sync** on the phone has **Sync now** too.
- Pictures are synced too, so a photo taken on the phone appears on the PC, and the other way round.
- Categories, templates and the settings that belong to the journal (the daily word goal, the template used for new entries and whether prompts show) travel along with your entries.

- If the server can't be reached, the status says **Paused, will try again**. Your journal is unaffected and nothing is lost.

If you change the same entry on two devices

Change different entries, or different parts of one entry, on both devices and everything simply merges. If the *text* of the same entry is changed on two devices before they meet, neither version is thrown away. One stays as it is and the other becomes a separate entry whose title ends with (**conflicting version from …**). Read both, keep what you want and delete the other.

Deleting works the same way on every device. An entry you delete goes to Recently deleted on your other devices too.

Managing sync

ROW	WHAT IT DOES
Diary name and status	The top row shows the diary's name and when it last synced (or "Paused" if the server couldn't be reached). **Sync now** syncs straight away.
Add another device	**Show QR code** shows a code for the phone to scan. **Copy details** copies the server address and sync code to type in instead.
Rename diary	**Rename…** changes the diary's name everywhere.
Sync code	**Manage…** opens a window to show the code, to **make a new code** (the old one stops working at once, on every device, so use it if you think someone has seen it) and to **use a new code** that was made on another device.
Server	The server address this PC syncs with.
Turn off sync	Stops syncing on this PC after a second click to confirm. Nothing is deleted from the journal or the server, and you can connect again later.

On the phone these live under **Settings → Sync**, as a status card, **Add another device** and a short **Manage** list (rename, sync code, server, turn off).

Starting a new journal

A device that starts a new journal leaves the old one's copy behind on the server, because the apps cannot delete it. Your other devices keep using the old journal until you move them across: on a PC, use **Join a synced diary** (above). It is still encrypted and cannot be read, but it does take up a little space. A future version of the server will have a way to clear it out.

Keeping it safe

- Everything on the server is encrypted before it leaves your device. Even so, run the server only on a network you trust, or behind a VPN, because the connection itself is plain HTTP for now.
- The server backs its own database up when it starts and then daily (if anything changed), into a `backups` folder beside `tideline-server.db`, keeping the newest 14. Copy that folder to another drive now and then: a backup beside the database does not help if the whole drive is lost. The copies are encrypted, so they are safe to keep anywhere.
- To check on it, run `tideline-server status`. It lists what the server holds and when the last backup was made, and warns if backups have stopped. To go back to a backup, stop the server and run `tideline-server restore` followed by the backup file; the database it replaces is kept aside, and your devices catch up on their next sync. Even without any backup, your PC and phone each hold the full journal (see "If the server is lost" below).
- Your journal password and your sync code are separate. The password protects what is *in* the journal; the sync code only controls who can use your diary on the server.

If the server is lost

Your PC and phone each keep a full copy of the journal, so losing the server never loses entries. It only means setting the server up again. These steps have been tested.

If you have a server backup

1. Stop the server (press Enter in its window) and start a new, empty folder for it if needed.
2. Run `tideline-server restore` followed by a file from the `backups` folder, for example `tideline-server restore backups\tideline-server-2026-10-21-090000.db`. Use this command rather than copying the file yourself: it also marks the database as restored.
3. Start the server again. Each device notices the server has gone back in time and, on its next sync, sends it whatever it is missing. Entries written after the backup are not lost, even if they were only on one device.

If you have no backup

1. Start a new, empty server.
2. On the PC, open **Settings → Sync**, turn sync off, and set it up again with the new server's address. This makes a new sync code and sends the whole journal to the server.
3. On the phone, open **Settings → Sync → Sync code** and enter or scan the PC's new code under **Changed on another device?**. Anything you wrote on the phone while the server was gone is sent, and the PC's entries arrive.

Until you do this, each device shows **Paused** and says the server did not accept its sync code. Your journal on each device is not affected.

If something goes wrong

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO TRY
"Paused, will try again"	The server may be switched off or the PC or phone may be on a different network. Check the server is running and the address is right. It retries by itself.
The phone can't reach the server on Wi-Fi	The PC running the server may need Windows Firewall to allow port **8787**, or its network set to **Private**.
"The sync code was changed"	Another device changed the code. Open **Sync code → Manage…** and enter (or, on the phone, scan) the new one under **Changed on another device?**.
The QR code won't scan	Make the QR code larger on the PC (`Ctrl` + `+`), turn the screen brightness up, or press **Copy details** and type them in.

CHAPTER 15

AI helpers

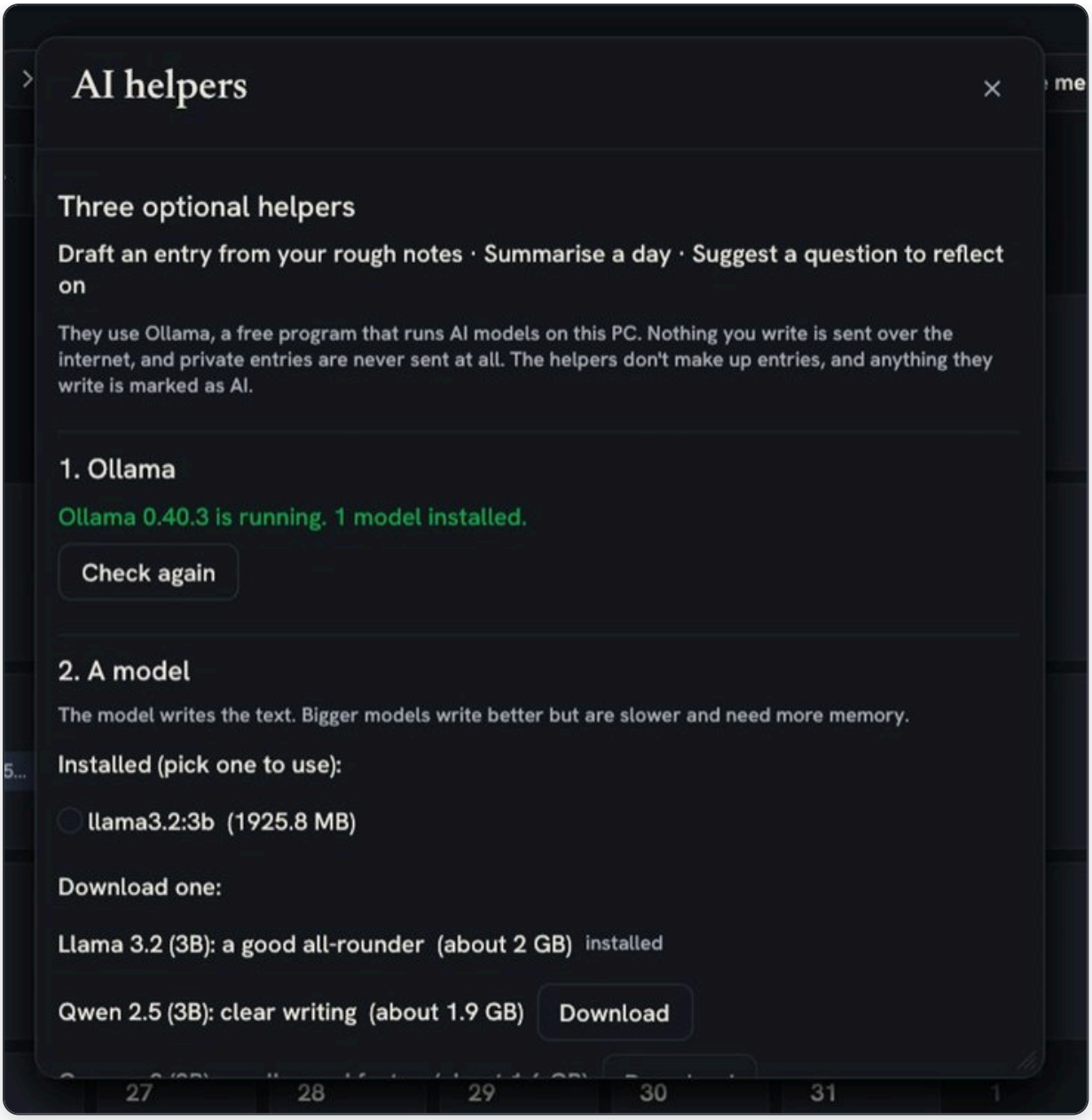
Three optional helpers that run entirely on your own computer. They are off until you set them up.

What they do

- **Turn my notes into an entry** (in the writing page's **Ask AI** menu): jot rough notes, then have them written up in your voice. You choose **Add below my notes** or **Replace my notes** (or **Write it again**).
- **Summarise** (on a day's panel): writes a short summary of that day's entries and can save it with **Save as an entry**, marked "AI summary".
- **Suggest a question to reflect on** (**Ask AI** menu): proposes a thoughtful question based on your recent entries, which you can use with **Use as a heading** (or ask for **Another question**).

Setting them up

Open **Settings → Writing → AI helpers → Set up**. The window walks you through three steps.



The AI helpers window.

1. **Ollama.** The helpers use *Ollama*, a free program that runs AI models on your PC. If it is not installed, the window offers to install it for you (you tick a box confirming that you understand it downloads a large file), or to open its download page. If it is installed but not running, `Start Ollama` launches it, and `Check again` re-checks after you install.
2. **A model.** Pick one that is installed, or download one (for example Llama 3.2, Qwen 2.5, Gemma 2 or Phi-3 mini). Bigger models write better but are slower and need more memory. A progress bar shows the download.
3. **Switch the helpers on.** Tick `Use the AI helpers`. You can try the model first with `Test it`. The helper buttons then appear.

How your privacy is protected

- The program only ever talks to Ollama on **this PC**. Nothing is sent over the internet.
- **Private entries are never sent**, and neither are summaries the AI wrote earlier.
- The helpers are told to use only what you wrote and not to invent anything. Each result window has **Show exactly what was sent to Ollama**.
- Nothing is saved until you choose to, and you can edit the text first. Entries containing AI text are marked **AI-assisted**; day summaries are marked **AI summary**, and don't count towards your word counts, streaks or statistics.

> **GOOD TO KNOW**
>
> The first answer can take a minute while the model loads into memory. The helpers are entirely optional; the rest of the program works the same without them.

CHAPTER 16

Keyboard shortcuts

You can do almost everything without the mouse.

Anywhere

KEYS	ACTION
Ctrl + N	New entry on the selected day
Ctrl + F	Search entries
Ctrl + T	Jump to today
Ctrl + R	Jump to a random entry (Surprise me)
Ctrl + L	Lock the journal
Ctrl + E	Export entries to PDF
F11	Full screen on or off (also works on the unlock screen)
Ctrl + + / Ctrl + −	Bigger or smaller text (Ctrl + 0 resets)

On the calendar

KEYS	ACTION
← / →	Previous or next month, week, day or year
Ctrl + 1 … 5	Day, Week, Month, Year and Photos view
Double-click	On a day: new entry. On an entry: edit it
Drag	Move an entry to another day or hour
Esc	Cancel a drag

While writing

KEYS	ACTION
Ctrl + S or Ctrl + Enter	Save the entry
Ctrl + D	Pin or unpin the entry
Ctrl + B / Ctrl + I	Bold / italic
Enter **(in the title)**	Move into the text
Click again	A mood button or toolbar format switches itself off

CHAPTER 17

Troubleshooting and questions

I forgot my password

If you made a recovery key, use **Forgot your password?** on the unlock screen (see chapter 12). Without a recovery key there is no way back in, which is what keeps your journal private. If you have an older backup whose password you remember, **Open a different diary…** can open it.

The window is hiding my entries

“Hide when in the background” blanks the window while it is not the one you are using. Click the window to show it again, or turn the setting off under **Settings → Security**.

The journal locked while I was away

That is Auto-lock. Enter your password to continue; anything you were writing is still there. You can lengthen or turn off Auto-lock under **Settings → Security**.

I deleted an entry by mistake

Press **Undo** at the top of the day panel straight away, or open **Settings → Your data → Recently deleted** and press **Restore**. Entries stay there for 30 days.

I can't find an entry

Try **Timeline** or search with fewer words. Check that no filter is switched on in the search box, and remember private entries can't be found by their text. They show on their day as "Private entry".

Saving fails, or the program says it cannot find a path

The journal folder may be on a drive that is full, read-only or no longer plugged in. Check the drive, or use **Settings → Your data → Data location** to see where the journal is meant to be.

A restored backup asks for a different password

A backup keeps the password it had when it was made. Use that password (or its recovery key).

Windows warns that the program may not be safe

The program is not code-signed. In the "Windows protected your PC" window choose **More info → Run anyway**. If Windows refuses outright because Smart App Control is on, you can use the program on a PC where that is switched off.

Letters or symbols appear as empty boxes in a PDF

PDF exports use the fonts installed on your PC. Characters those fonts don't have, such as some emoji, show as boxes.

Where do I find this guide again?

Settings → Help → User guide. You can open it, or save a copy anywhere you like.

> LAST WORD
>
> Write a little, often. Every day leaves a mark.